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Bernard Lonergan

Lex Crucis and the Dialectics of History

A vector, an undertow, a fateful call to dread holiness

The Jesuit residence at Regis College in Toronto was a dingy place when Bernard Lonergan joined the faculty of theology there in 1947. Purchased in 1930 from an order of nuns who had transformed a once fashionable private home into a convent,

it was surrounded on three sides by factories and at the rear by the main rail yard of Union Station. Freight trains spent the night shunting to build up their cargo for their journey the next day. The house . . . was constantly showered with soot and grime from the coal fires of the steam engines. In the estimation of many, it was a health hazard.¹

Father Lonergan would spend six years at Regis. Despite the insalubrious surroundings, he put the time afforded him by a light teaching load to good use. In 1949, he completed a revolutionary reconstruction of Aquinas's theory of knowledge.² Four years later,

1. William A. Mathews, *Lonergan's Quest: A Study of Desire in the Authoring of Insight* (Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 2005), 177.

2. *Verbum: Word and Idea in Aquinas*, Collected Works of Bernard Lonergan 2, Frederick E. Crowe and

having been reassigned to teach in Rome, he felt pressured to finish another manuscript before he left Regis. At the Gregorian University, he had been told, there would be no time to write, and this seemed plausible in light of the enormous size of the classes he would be facing.³ Hence, Lonergan spent his last few months at Regis drafting the final chapters of the work that would appear in 1957 as *Insight: A Study in Human Understanding*,⁴ a book that would claim its place as one of the classics of twentieth-century philosophy.

Bernard J. F. Lonergan was born in Buckingham, a lumber town in Quebec, in 1904. That same year also saw the birth of two other future giants of twentieth-century Catholic theology, Karl Rahner and Yves Congar. At thirteen, Lonergan was sent off to boarding school with the Jesuits in Toronto. Upon graduating from Loyola, drawn to the piety and erudition of “the best educated men I had met,”⁵ he joined the order. With this decision, he embarked upon the lengthy course of studies prescribed for Jesuits which, in his case, would stretch out over seventeen years. Jesuit training began with two years of spiritual formation at Guelph, Ontario, toward the beginning of which, novices made the thirty-day Long Retreat according to the Spiritual Exercises of Saint Ignatius Loyola. At the close of their novitiate, young Jesuits of the Canadian Province took their vows and moved on, still under the same roof, to two years in the juniorate, where their studies centered on Latin and Greek classics, along with English and math. There followed four years of philosophy, for which Lonergan was sent with two other Canadians to the Jesuits’ Heythrop College in England. Here, he was marched through the prescribed sequence of neoscholastic

Robert M. Doran, eds. (Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 1997). First published as a series of articles entitled “The Concept of *Verbum* in the Thought of St. Thomas Aquinas” in *Theological Studies*, 1945–49.

3. In an interview in 1970, Lonergan recalled teaching classes of six hundred fifty students. Philip McShane, ed., “An Interview with Fr. Bernard Lonergan, S. J.,” in Bernard J. F. Lonergan, S. J., *A Second Collection*, eds. William F. J. Ryan, S. J. and Bernard J. Tyrrell, S. J. (Philadelphia: Westminster Press, 1974), 211.

4. *Insight, A Study of Human Understanding*, Collected Works of Bernard Lonergan 3, Frederick E. Crowe and Robert M. Doran, eds. (Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 2005). First published in 1957 by Longmans, Greene & Co., London.

5. Pierre Lambert, Charlotte Tansey, Cathleen Going, eds., *Caring About Meaning: Patterns in the Life of Bernard Lonergan* (Montreal: Thomas Moore Institute Papers: 1982), 135.

tracts while also matriculating for a B. A. in classics and mathematics at the University of London. Unimpressed by the decadent scholasticism of the day—his professors convinced him that a problem of human knowledge indeed existed, but not that a solution could be found in their texts or lectures⁶—Lonerган found solace in multiple readings of John Henry Newman’s *Grammar of Assent*. This interest led to one of his earliest publications, a paper on Newman’s illative sense, written for *Blandyke Papers*, the in-house journal. Later, while studying theology in Rome, he would prepare a thirty-thousand-word essay on Newman for one of his professors.⁷

From Heythrop, Lonergan was sent back to Toronto to teach high school for two years at his alma mater, where a run-in with the local superior prolonged his stint for an extra year. Toronto was in the grip of the Great Depression, and Lonergan used his free time to launch himself into a study of economics. Humanitarian prescriptions for the ills of the economy, he recognized, proved inefficacious. Employers might well be morally obliged to pay a family wage, but those who did so went bankrupt. Lonergan’s response was to take up the study of economics in search of moral precepts that would be grounded in the reality of the economy itself. He pursued this interest for the next decade, and he would return to it again years later, in his retirement. The immediate upshot was a trio of substantive essays completed in the early 1940s, entitled “For a New Political Economy,” “Essay Toward a Pure Theory of Social Economics,”⁸ and “Circulation Analysis.”⁹

The fall of 1933 found Lonergan back in Europe. He had been selected to attend the Gregorian University in Rome for the four-year course in theology, with ordination to the priesthood coming at the end of the third year. A letter to his provincial superior written in January 1935 makes it clear that, beyond his seminary studies and his ongoing work

6. Mathews, *Lonerган’s Quest*, 35.

7. See David M. Hammond, “The Influence of Newman’s Doctrine of Assent on the Thought of Bernard Lonergan: A Genetic Study,” *Method: Journal of Lonergan Studies* 7:2 (1989): 95–115.

8. *For a New Political Economy*, Collected Works of Bernard Lonergan 21, ed. Philip J. McShane (Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 1998).

9. *Macroeconomic Dynamics: An Essay in Circulation Analysis*, Collected Works of Bernard Lonergan 15, Patrick H. Byrne, Frederick G. Lawrence and Charles Hefling, Jr., eds. (Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 1999).

on economics, a further concern had captured Lonergan's imagination. In 1931, Pope Pius XI had issued *Quadragesimo Anno*, in which he condemned Marxist materialism and called for an intensive study of social reality. In January 1933, Adolf Hitler had become chancellor of the Third Reich, and he found a ready ally in Italy in Benito Mussolini's fascist regime. What the times called for, Lonergan wrote, was a "metaphysics of history" that would inform the church's understanding of its identity and redemptive role as the Mystical Body of Christ.¹⁰ He had already begun working on this task, Lonergan informed his superior, and he asked permission to continue pursuing it. A series of papers written between 1933 and 1938 document Lonergan's first efforts in this regard.¹¹ They bear such titles as "An Analytic Conception of History," "A Philosophy of History," "A Theory of History," "An Essay on Fundamental Sociology," and "Sketch for a Metaphysic of Human Solidarity." The title of one essay, drawn from St. Paul's Letter to the Ephesians, indicates that in all this, he sought to clarify the historical character of the redemption instituted by Christ: "Pantôn Anakephalaiôsis: A Theory of Human Solidarity."¹²

In one further respect, Lonergan's years as a theology student in Rome marked a crucial milestone in the development of his thought. By the time he had completed the philosophy course at Heythrop, he had developed an aversion to the neoscholastic fetish of universal concepts, and so, styled himself a nominalist, albeit a nominalist tempered by his study of Newman's analysis of judgment. While teaching high school at Loyola, he had found in reading J. A. Stewart's Kantian-inspired *Plato's Doctrine of Ideas* what he would recall as "a great release. From Stewart I learnt that Plato was a methodologist, that his ideas were what the scientist seeks to discover, that the scientific or philosophic process towards discovery was one of question and

10. Mathews, *Lonergan's Quest*, 79.

11. See Michael Shute, *The Origins of Lonergan's Notion of the Dialectic of History: A Study of Lonergan's Early Writings on History* (Lanham, MD: University Press of America, 1993).

12. Two of these papers have been published: "Lonergan's *Pantôn Anakephalaiôsis* [The Restoration of All Things]," *Method: Journal of Lonergan Studies* 9 (1991): 134–72; "Lonergan's 'Analytic Concept of History,'" *Method: Journal of Lonergan Studies* 11 (1993): 1–35. On these and "Philosophy of History" see Joseph A. Komonchak, "Lonergan's Early Essays on the Redemption of History," *Lonergan Workshop* 10 (1994): 159–77.

answer.”¹³ Following up on Stewart, Lonergan read through Plato’s dialogues and then turned to Augustine’s early writings. Plato brought into focus the conscious act of understanding that intervenes between the data from which inquiry takes its rise and the formation of a concept—an act thoroughly disregarded in scholastic manuals of epistemology. Augustine, in turn, impressed upon Lonergan the immutability of truth.

The encounter with Plato and Augustine propelled Lonergan beyond the “nominalism” of his days at Heythrop, but further events in Rome would prompt him eventually to characterize Platonic idealism as but a philosophical half-way house.¹⁴ While following Bernard Leeming’s course in Christology, he came upon the distinction between Christ’s person and natures drawn by the Council of Chalcedon (451 AD). Philosophically, that dogmatically established distinction required a more general distinction between essence and existence, and with that distinction, Lonergan found himself driven beyond Platonic idealism into Aquinas’s metaphysics, a development that he would later recall as marking his intellectual conversion. This turn was reinforced by conversations Lonergan was having with a fellow seminarian who had studied philosophy at Louvain, where the thought of Joseph Maréchal prevailed. Maréchal offered a post-Kantian reading of Aquinas that paid heed to the dynamic finality of human intellectual activity in a way that undercut Kant’s restriction of human knowing to the realm of the phenomenal and opened a path to the retrieval of metaphysics and to valid natural knowledge of the existence of God. Thus, during his seminary studies in Rome, Leeming’s Christology course and conversations about Maréchal conspired to make of Lonergan a Thomist.¹⁵

After four years at the Gregorian, he proceeded to Amiens in France for a final year of spiritual formation, following which he was ordered

13. Mathews, *Lonergan’s Quest*, 54.

14. Lonergan, *Insight*, 22.

15. Lonergan is explicit: “I had become a Thomist through the influence of Maréchal mediated to me by Stefanos Stefanu and through Bernard Leeming’s lectures on the *unicum esse* of Christ.” “Insight Revisited,” *A Second Collection*, 276.

back to Rome for the two-year doctoral program in theology. At his director's suggestion, he chose Aquinas's doctrine on operative grace as the topic for his dissertation.¹⁶ Central to the topic was the question of the relationship between divine grace and human freedom, and it had provoked a controversy that roiled post-Tridentine Catholic theology. Members of the Dominican order espoused the position of Domingo Bañez (1528–1604), who emphasized the efficaciousness of grace, while Jesuits followed Luis de Molina (1535–1600) in his insistence on the role of human freedom. The controversy was both protracted and heated, with charges of heresy hurled by both sides until a papal intervention imposed a truce. Lonergan, it was anticipated, would once again vindicate the Molinist position, but he quickly came to realize that neither side faithfully represented the actual thought of Aquinas and that Aquinas's solution lay in the broader context of his conception of the relation of God's causality to the order of the universe. As transcendent, that causality was equally efficacious through both necessary and contingent secondary causes, and thus, through genuine human freedom.

This last step in Lonergan's formal education ended in a rush. He completed and deposited his dissertation, but two days before he was scheduled to defend it, he hastily boarded the last ship departing Italy for North America. War had broken out. Lonergan would remain in Canada for the next thirteen years, teaching theology first at the Collège de l'Immaculée Conception in Montreal, and then at Regis College in Toronto. Called back to Rome in 1953, he spent the next dozen years at the Gregorian, alternating between Trinitarian theology and Christology in his cycle of courses. The hefty textbooks that he produced on each topic manifest the strain he experienced in trying to contain his interests within the genre of the neoscholastic manual.¹⁷

16. *Grace and Freedom: Operative Grace in the Thought of St. Thomas Aquinas*, Collected Works of Bernard Lonergan 1, Frederick E. Crowe and Robert M. Doran, eds. (Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 2000).

17. *The Triune God: Doctrines*, Collected Works of Bernard Lonergan 11, trans. Michael G. Shields, Robert M. Doran and H. Daniel Monsour, eds. (Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 2009); *The Triune God: Systematics*, Collected Works of Bernard Lonergan 12, trans. Michael G. Shields, Robert M. Doran and H. Daniel Monsour, eds. (Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 2007), *De Verbo Incarnato* (Rome, Gregorian University Press, 1964, 3rd edition).

In 1965, surgery for lung cancer cut short his teaching career and he returned to Canada. From 1965 until 1975, Lonergan enjoyed the hospitality of Regis College, which had secured more congenial and salubrious housing since his initial sojourn there. In 1971–72, he interrupted this time as research professor at Regis to serve as Stillman Professor at Harvard Divinity School, and in 1972, the project he had initiated with *Insight* came to completion with the appearance of *Method in Theology*.¹⁸ In 1975, he accepted an appointment as Visiting Distinguished Professor at Boston College, offering a doctoral seminar each year on “Economics and the Dialectics of History,” and he remained there until 1983, when failing health returned him to the Jesuit infirmary at Guelph, where his younger brother Gregory, also a Jesuit, was in residence. Lonergan died on November 26, 1984.

The Latin Textbook

Lonergan taught Christology twice in Canada, in 1948 and 1952, and each time, he availed himself of an expedient common among seminary professors and taught the course from a manual.¹⁹ Once in Rome, he did the same, this time lecturing from the textbook composed by his predecessor on the faculty and former dissertation director, Charles Boyer. Practical considerations seem to have determined this choice; the Boyer text was available in sufficient numbers in the university bookstore. Seven years later, as the Boyer text was running out of stock, Lonergan hurriedly published his own manual, with an expanded final version appearing in 1964.²⁰

The Christological manual, governed by Leo XIII’s mandate that Catholic theology was to be taught according to the mind of Thomas Aquinas, exhibited a three-part sequence. Following upon the course on the Trinity, it began by asking how a divine person could become incarnate, and in response, it worked out the metaphysical terms and

18. *Method in Theology* (Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 2003).

19. Lonergan used Adhémar d’Alès, *De Verbo Incarnato* (Paris: Beauchesne, 1930). Frederick E. Crowe S.J. sat in the 1948 course and discusses it and the other Canadian course in *Christ and History: The Christology of Bernard Lonergan from 1935 to 1982* (Ottawa: Novalis, 2005), 51–63.

20. Lonergan, *De Verbo Incarnato*.

relations comprising the intelligibility of the dogma promulgated by the Council of Chalcedon in 451. Next, still in tandem with Aquinas's treatment in the *Pars Tertia* of his *Summa Theologiae*, the manual enumerated the impact on Christ's humanity of being assumed by a divine person. Thus, Christ was endowed with the fullness of grace, a free but sinless human will, and a human intellect informed by the beatific vision and specially infused knowledge as well as ordinary, experiential knowledge. The manual then skipped over Thomas's lengthy treatment of the biblical narrative. Guided by the creed, Thomas had incorporated into his Christology a commonly misnamed *vita Jesu*, which ranged from Christ's virginal conception through his birth, presentation in the Temple, Baptism, manner of life, preaching and miracles, and extended through his passion, death, resurrection, and ascension to his establishment as eschatological judge at the Father's right hand. Omitting all this, the manual concluded by asking how the incarnate divine person, equipped with numerous perfections of grace and nature, in fact redeemed the human race by his death, and here, it ordinarily presented some version of the notion of satisfaction.

Three supplements that he composed for his students while teaching out of Boyer's text give some indication of where Lonergan's interests lay while he was lecturing on Christology. The first, a set of mimeographed notes produced in 1954, addresses matters both methodological and substantive. It bears the lengthy title *De ratione convenientiae ejusque radice, de signis rationis systematicae et universaliter ordinatis, denique de convenientia, contingentia, et fine incarnationis. Supplementum schematicum*.²¹ *Convenientia*, we have seen, provided the key to Aquinas's theological method, and the question of the purpose of the incarnation had divided Thomists from Franciscans since the Middle Ages. Next, in 1956, Lonergan produced a second supplement, this time published in book form, entitled *De constitutione Christi ontologica et psychologica*.²² The question of Christ's human

21. Lonergan, *The Notion of Fittingness: The Application of Theological Method to the Question of the Purpose of the Incarnation*, Latin text with translation by Michael Shields in *Early Latin Theology*, Collected Works of Bernard Lonergan 19, eds. Robert M. Doran and H. Daniel Monsour (Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 2011), 482–533.

consciousness was novel in the twentieth century, and Lonergan's resolution of it drew on the analysis of human cognitive activity he had discovered in the *Verbum* articles on Aquinas and transposed to the modern context in *Insight*. An unfavorable review of the book prompted Lonergan to publish a response, "Christ as Subject: A Reply."²³ Third, Lonergan's correspondence from the period indicates that in 1957–58, he had substantively completed a work on the redemption that he also intended as a supplement to the Christology course. The work did not, however, appear during Lonergan's lifetime. After his death, it was discovered among his papers in an incomplete manuscript comprising some three hundred pages. Initially circulating under a title borrowed from its first chapter, *De bono et malo*, the manuscript has been edited and translated under the title *The Redemption: A Supplement to De Verbo Incarnato*.²⁴ If this work never reached its intended audience, it at least informed a public lecture Lonergan presented in Montreal in the late summer of 1958, entitled "The Redemption."²⁵

These supplements all fed into the final version of Lonergan's Latin Christology that he published in 1964. Conforming to the genre of the neoscholastic manual, he unfolded his material in a series of seventeen theses, for each of which, as convention required, he defined the terms, assigned the "theological note" that determined the degree of authority the thesis claimed, listed various opinions and adversaries, and presented the argument. At the same time, he stuffed his theses with prenotes and scholia in which he addressed metaphysical and

22. Lonergan, *The ontological and psychological constitution of Christ*, Latin text with English translation by Michael Shields, *Collected Works of Bernard Lonergan* 7, eds. Frederick E. Crowe and Robert M. Doran (Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 2002.)

23. "Christ as Subject: A Reply," in F. E. Crowe, ed., *Collection: Papers by Bernard Lonergan* (New York, Herder & Herder, 1967), 164–97; originally published in *Gregorianum* 40 (1959): 242–70.

24. Lonergan, "The Redemption: A Supplement to *De Verbo Incarnato*," trans. Michael Shields from *De bono et malo* (Toronto: Lonergan Research Center, 2000). On the text and its history, see F. Crowe, *Christ and History*, 99–125, and John Volk, "Lonergan on the Historical Causality of Christ: An Interpretation of 'The Redemption: A Supplement to *De Verbo Incarnato*'" (unpublished dissertation. Milwaukee: Marquette University, 2009).

25. Lonergan, "The Redemption," *Philosophical and Theological Papers 1958–1964*, *Collected Works of Bernard Lonergan* 6, eds. Robert C. Croken, Frederick E. Crowe, Robert M. Doran (Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 1996), 1–28.

historical issues that he found germane to the topic at hand. New wine was filling the old skin to the bursting point.

Three Theses

Following the order of topics dictated by the genre of the manual, Lonergan rounds off his textbook with a consideration of the redemption. He will deal, he announces,²⁶ first with what the New Testament teaches on the matter (Thesis 15), then with the dogma of satisfaction (Thesis 16), and he will conclude by addressing the theological questions that are customarily posed about the redemption, with the aim of reaching some imperfect understanding of the mystery (Thesis 17).

Scripture. Thesis 15 asserts that “redemption expresses not only an end but also mediation, namely, a price paid, the vicarious passion and death of Christ the mediator because of sins and for sinners, the sacrifice offered by our High Priest in his blood, meritorious obedience, the power of the risen Lord, and the intercession of the eternal Priest.” The goal of the thesis, Lonergan states, is simply to ascertain what is clearly contained in Scripture and universally proclaimed by the church. Given this status of the material, he assigns the thesis the highest theological note, “de fide divina et catholica.” Three prenotes precede the presentation of the argument. In the first prenote, Lonergan summarizes what is “clearly, certainly, and commonly acknowledged” with respect to the death of Christ, namely, that in God’s wisdom, God permitted the malice of those who cooperated in persecuting Christ, indirectly willed the affliction of Christ that resulted from that malice, and directly willed the love and obedience out of which Christ freely accepted his passion. Two further prenotes appeal to contemporary exegetical scholarship to clarify the biblical vocabulary and show how it yields the distinction between redemption as end and as mediation. The argument that follows proceeds by assembling New Testament texts that witness to each member of the

26. Lonergan, *DVI*, 445.

thesis. A scholion then reveals the perspective that informed the construction of the thesis. In the scholion, Lonergan correlates the individual members of the thesis with Aquinas's exposition of the modes and effects of the redemption in questions 48 and 49 of the *Pars Tertia* of the *Summa Theologiae*. Aquinas's influence was also patent in the first prenote to the thesis, which recapitulated Aquinas's treatment of the efficient causality of Christ's passion in *ST III*, 47.

Satisfaction. Aquinas had counted satisfaction among the modes of efficacy of Christ's passion, but because Lonergan finds discordant opinions among both classical and contemporary theologians on the meaning of the concept, he devotes a separate thesis to it.²⁷ Thesis 16 reads:

Christ satisfied for our sins not only condignly but also superabundantly. This satisfaction is to be understood on a sacramental analogy. Thus, it adds to the vicarious passion and death the expression of the utmost detestation of all sins and the utmost sorrow at every offense against God.²⁸

In the outline with which he prefaced his theses on the redemption Lonergan had written that this thesis would deal with the "dogma" of satisfaction, but when he comes to assign a theological note to the thesis, he seems to hedge. A text from the Council of Trent, he notes, presupposed that Christ had made satisfaction by his passion but did not formally define the doctrine. The doctrine can be found implicit in scripture and explicit in the ordinary magisterium. So, what degree of authority can the thesis claim? Lonergan contents himself with citing another theologian. Paul Galtier, he observes, ranks the doctrine of satisfaction as "proximum fidei," that is, held by almost all to have been revealed. We may note that Galtier is more forceful than Charles Boyer, whose text Lonergan had been using, and who commented only that the doctrine was "common at least for many centuries."²⁹

Perhaps the scope of Lonergan's thesis explains why he seems

27. On this topic, see Charles C. Hefling, Jr., "A Perhaps Permanently Valid Achievement: Lonergan on Christ's Satisfaction," *Method: Journal of Lonergan Studies* 10 (1992): 51–76.

28. Lonergan, *DVI*, 486.

29. Boyer, *De Verbo Incarnato*, 331: "communis saltem a multis saeculis."

somewhat noncommittal in assigning it a theological note. The thesis affirms Christ's satisfaction as a fact: "Christ satisfied for our sins not only condignly but also superabundantly." It then addresses the intelligibility of the fact: "This satisfaction is to be understood on a sacramental analogy." With this latter move, Lonergan took up the task of systematic theology as he understood it to have been commended by Vatican I. As he would later remark,

. . . the first Vatican council retrieved the notion of understanding. It taught that reason illumined by faith, when it inquires diligently, piously, soberly, can with God's help attain a highly fruitful understanding of the mysteries of faith both from the analogy of what it naturally knows and from the interconnection of the mysteries with one another and with man's last end (DS 3016). The promotion of such an understanding we take to be the principal function of systematics.³⁰

This notion of the task of systematic theology stood somewhat at odds with the genre of the theological manual. The basic unit of the manual was the thesis, its procedure was proof, most often from authority, and its goal was some degree of certitude—hence the theological notes. Catholic theology had adopted this genre in the wake of the Reformation, and it served both an apologetic function as a demonstration of the truth of Catholic doctrine and a pedagogical function, equipping the clergy with knowledge of that doctrine. Thomas Aquinas's theology, however, had a different set of priorities.³¹ He structured his *Summa Theologiae* as a series of questions, not theses, and his goal was understanding, not certitude. This was the conception of systematic theology that, on Lonergan's reading, Vatican I had retrieved, and he labored to pursue it within the inhospitable genre of the manual.

Thesis 16 would thus seem to have a hybrid character. It affirms as ecclesial doctrine the satisfaction made by Christ, but it goes on to propose an analogy with which to fix the meaning of the doctrine. In so doing, the thesis combines what Lonergan would later distinguish

30. Lonergan, *Method in Theology*, 336.

31. Lonergan, "Theology and Understanding," *Collection*, 121–41.

as the functional theological specialties of doctrines and systematics. Furthermore, the meaning of the doctrine was contested, so that in order to ensure the fidelity of his interpretation to the Catholic tradition, Lonergan felt compelled delve into the history of the notion of satisfaction. Accordingly, he prefaces the argument of the thesis with a ten-and-a-half-page survey of opinions drawn largely from the historical investigations of Jean Rivière, Louis Richard, and R. S. Franks.³² Not content to merely chronicle this material, he first shows how Aquinas enriches and completes the notion introduced by Anselm, and he sets up a dialectic showing how and why other authors differ from Thomas's position. He then follows up on this survey of opinions with a series of eleven prenotes that extends over another forty pages. In these prenotes, he works out the terms and relations that comprise the theory of satisfaction introduced by Anselm and completed by Aquinas on which the sacramental analogy of his thesis is founded. Of themselves, the prenotes constitute a compact treatise. Once this has been secured, Lonergan can make short work of the actual argument that completes his thesis.

In all of this, Lonergan seems fully aware that he is pushing the limits of the manual genre. Thus, immediately after proposing his thesis and before launching into his survey of opinions, he offers a summary statement of the basic sense of the thesis as an aid for those who may find the length and complexity of the prenotes that follow daunting. Along the way, he also addresses an objection that was apparently common in his day and remains so among seminary students at present. There are those, he observes, "who say that disputed matters should be omitted and what all good Catholics profess should be clearly enunciated."³³ Theology, in the view of some, should stick to presenting what the Church teaches and not confuse matters with idle questions. Lonergan's response subjects this commonsensical

32. Jean Rivière, *Le dogme de la rédemption: essai d'étude historique* (Paris: V. Lecoffre, 1905); Louis Richard, *Le mystère de la rédemption* (Tournai: Desclée, 1959); Robert S. Franks, *The Work of Christ: A Historical Study of Christian Doctrine* (London: Thomas Nelson and Sons Ltd., 1962). Originally published in 1918 as *A History of the Doctrine of the Work of Christ*.

33. Lonergan, DVI, 489.

objection to a sort of retorsion. He points out that the objection itself requires that a judgment be made regarding the material to be included in the study of theology. Such a judgment may be made intelligently and wisely or not, and, if intelligently and wisely, then precisely the exercise of theological understanding commended by Vatican I comes into play. Doctrinal positivism is not a theological option for Lonergan.

First, then, the sense of the thesis in brief: Thesis 15 had ascertained that Scripture affirms “the vicarious passion and death of Christ the mediator because of sins and for sinners,” and Lonergan takes this to indicate not only the purpose and beneficiaries of Christ’s passion, but also Christ’s motivation in undergoing it. The notion of satisfaction interprets this fact of Christ’s motivation by setting it in an intelligible context systematically constructed on the interrelated notions of sin and punishment, God’s justice, and redemption. Key to this interpretation is the distinction between two contexts in which one can speak of “paying the penalty” or “undergoing punishment” for sin, namely, a context ruled by the notion of vindictive or retributive justice and another, quite different context constituted by the notions of “pardon sought and granted, of hatred and sorrow over the offense, with the remission of fault and punishment alike.” Christ’s satisfaction, the thesis avers, belongs to the second context, not the first, from which it follows that in the actual order that obtains in this world, the notion of divine justice embraces both contexts; divine justice operates to effect both punishment for sin and redemption from sin.

Lonergan’s prenotes begin with the originator of the theory of satisfaction, Anselm of Canterbury. The crux of interpretation lies in the disjunction at which Anselm arrived in Book I of the *Cur Deus Homo*. In the face of human sin, God’s justice requires *aut satisfactio*, *aut poena*—either satisfaction or punishment. If this amounts to a distinction between two forms of punishment, *aut poena aut poena*, then the Reformers can claim Anselm for the doctrine of penal substitution. Christ would have saved us by satisfying God’s retributive justice, undergoing the punishment for sin in our place. Catholic theologians,

Lonerган notes, are not unanimous on the matter, nor or they clear on just what satisfaction and punishment are. Hence, drawing upon Aquinas, he sets about rendering those notions precise. Liability to punishment follows upon the guilt incurred by an offense, and strictly speaking, the key to the concept of punishment is that it be an involuntary deprivation. Satisfaction, on the contrary, consists in the voluntary acceptance of a penalty in such a way that pardon for an offense can be suitably sought and granted. Vicarious satisfaction is a nineteenth-century term for what is also commonly called reparation. Its foundation, Thomas made clear, is a union of wills in love between the one guilty of the offense and the one who offers satisfaction. Drawing an analogy from Aristotle's theory of friendship, Thomas transformed and expanded Anselm's notion in several ways. For Anselm, it was because Christ's death was supererogatory, something that he, as sinless, did not already owe God, that it could serve as satisfaction. For Thomas, however, it was not its supererogatory character, but the love and obedience that animated it that conferred on Christ's passion and death the formal character of satisfaction. In Thomas's definition of satisfaction, namely, offering the one offended something that he loves more than he hates the offense, God loved the love and obedience of his Son more than he hated the offense of humankind. Personally one with the Word, Christ enjoyed a fullness of grace and charity whereby his human will was one with the divine will. In that fullness, he was constituted in his humanity as head of his body, the church, rendering those to whom he mediated grace his friends. Friends, however, can regard the deeds of their beloved as their own so that, as Thomas is fond of saying, all that Christ did and underwent was for our salvation. Specifically, he underwent the passion and death out of love and obedience for us and on account of sins. This satisfaction is vicarious in that it redounds to those who, as members of Christ's body, share in the deeds of the head with whom they are united in love and to whom they are conformed.

Besides transposing Anselm into a richly interpersonal context, Thomas also integrates Anselm's notion of satisfaction with the

previous tradition. For Anselm, the disjunction between satisfaction and punishment is complete. Christ satisfied for sin by offering his supererogatory death to God. The notion of death as punishment for sin plays no direct role in his theory. Yet, the earlier tradition, starting with St. Paul, regarded death as the wages of sin, so that in dying for our sins, Christ can be said to have taken on the penalty to which we were subject. Thomas integrates this tradition with Anselm's notion of satisfaction when, using Aristotle's hylomorphic theory as the basis for an analogy, he posits the passion and death of Christ as the material element in the satisfaction he offered. Yet, for Thomas, it is not simply by undergoing the punishment for sin that Christ redeems us. Rather, the formal element that confers on his passion and death the character of satisfaction is the love and obedience with which he embraced them.

For Thomas, then, satisfaction is not a matter of penal substitution. In becoming incarnate, the Son of God chose to suspend the overflow of his enjoyment of the beatific vision that would have rendered his body a glorified body. Whereas sinful human beings "contract" the subjection to suffering and mortality that constitutes the penalty of sin, the Son of God freely "assumed" or took on those "defects" of human nature that would enable him to undergo the passion. Then, when the malice of his persecutors reached its peak, Christ freely allowed that malice to work its effect, and so, his passion lacked the element of involuntary deprivation that constitutes punishment in the strict sense. Furthermore, since Christ was wholly innocent, in no way liable to God's retributive justice, to ascribe the suffering of the innocent Christ to that kind of divine justice would be to make of God an immoral monster. And yet, suffering and death, the penalty for sin, provide the material element that, by his human love and obedience, is transformed into the means of redemption. In all this, the priority lies with God's love, which freely, wisely and justly chose the actual order of the universe in which the evils of the human race become matter to be transformed through the passion of Christ into the greater good which is the body of Christ.

Having systematically elaborated the concept of satisfaction in a

manner that clarifies the Catholic doctrine and distinguishes it from a doctrine of penal substitution, Lonergan concludes his prenotes to the thesis with a brief consideration of what he terms “the symbolic mentality.” Far from systematically rigorous, this mode of thinking operates under the dominance of image and affect and follows a quasi-logic stemming from the psychic dimension of our humanity. Within this mode of thought, Christ’s passion can easily be apprehended as a matter of substitution and satisfassion, that is, adequate suffering. Contemplating the passion, one may reflect that what Christ suffered was what one deserved for sin, and that God found in Christ’s suffering, ample compensation for sin. Such an apprehension cannot be deemed false. Of itself, neither good nor bad, the symbolic mode of thinking can even be praiseworthy as an appropriation of the salvific impact of the Christ’s passion *pro me*. Only when this mode of spontaneous reflection is transposed from the symbolic to the logical order do the further questions arise that render it problematic.

With these lengthy preliminary considerations in place, Lonergan can move expeditiously through the argument of the thesis. That Christ died for our sins, the material element in satisfaction, is attested by Scripture, while the formal element can claim the authority of Anselm and Aquinas. That the satisfaction Christ offered was “condign,” that is, adequate, derives from the price he paid and the value of his sacrifice, as Hebrews proclaims. Whereas Durandus, Scotus, and the nominalists attribute this adequacy to an extrinsic factor, namely, the divine decision to so regard it, Lonergan finds it rooted in an intrinsic factor, namely, the degree of love Christ’s satisfaction embodies. For its superabundance, he cites Aquinas, for whom “a single least suffering” would have sufficed. Thus, God directly willed Christ’s satisfaction, and this indicates that in the entire work of redemption, a quasi-principle of transformation is operative. It belongs to the essence of redemption that God produces a greater good out of the evils God permits. Finally, then, the context of satisfaction and the remission of sin suggests a sacramental analogy where the difference from the sacrament of penance lies in the facts that Christ was guiltless and

that his satisfaction is the cause of the efficacy of the sacrament. In both Christ's passion and in the satisfaction performed by the penitent, however—and this is the point of the analogy—union with God in love gives rise to a deed that expresses hatred for sin and sorrow at every offense against the divine beloved.

The Law of the Cross. With Theses 15 and 16, Lonergan has recapitulated the *vetera* of Scripture and tradition on the redemption, and here, if the format of the manual genre prevailed, we might expect his Christological text to end. There follows, however, Thesis 17:

The Son of God thus became man, suffered, died, and was raised again, because the divine wisdom ordained and the divine goodness willed, not to eliminate the evils of the human race by power, but to convert those evils into a certain highest good through the just and mysterious law of the cross.

In his general introduction to the three theses with which he concludes his Christology, Lonergan said that Thesis 17 would deal with “theological questions which are customarily raised (*quae . . . proponi solent*) with the aim of reaching some imperfect understanding of the mystery.”³⁴ The aim of the thesis is a single, systematic understanding of both the incarnation and the redemption. Before launching into the argument for his thesis, however, Lonergan uses the conventional presentation of opinions and adversaries to clear the decks, as it were. He offers a critical historical review of “the questions which are customarily raised” in order to situate his thesis within the tradition and to clarify his methodological option.

He begins his review with the creedal affirmation that the incarnation took place “for us and for our salvation.” Hence, Lonergan observes, “it certainly follows that the purpose of the incarnation was the redemption of the human race.”³⁵ The Fathers illustrated this theme through the idea of divinization and through the notion that Christ redeemed us from the devil's yoke justly rather than by force. Further, they followed Scripture in teaching that Christ expiated for

34. Lonergan, *DVI*, 445.

35. *Ibid.*, 559.

our sins and that he offered himself as a sacrifice. Anselm, in turn, sought to deduce the incarnation by proving the necessity of a God-man to make the satisfaction required if God's intention in creating the human race was to prevail, but it was subsequently recognized that the necessity in question was conditioned and hypothetical: God could have saved us in many ways, but if God chose to save us through condign satisfaction, then the incarnation was necessary. This became the common opinion among Catholic theologians, though Scotus restricted the hypothetical necessity of the incarnation to God's *potentia ordinata*, as opposed to his *potentia absoluta*. Within the Thomist tradition, Cajetan and Vasquez seem to have entertained doubts about the matter, but on the contemporary scene, Galtier regards it as certain. Lonergan agrees. He goes on, however, to remark that logic-driven debate about hypothetically necessary matters contributes little to promoting theological understanding. The real, relevant question is what sense it makes that God chose the "hypothesis" he did, the question of the *convenientia* of the contingent matter of fact. Logical speculation about merely possible worlds moves away from reality into a realm that, as Aquinas taught, exceeds even the scope of the beatific vision enjoyed by Christ. Such speculation quickly becomes sterile.

Nonetheless, in the twelfth century, Rupert of Deutz had introduced into the schools the question whether Christ would have become incarnate had Adam not sinned. Scotists subsequently raised the question of the primary and secondary ends of the incarnation. They identified the exaltation of Christ as the primary end, and this entailed a positive response to Rupert's question. There followed a six-hundred-year dispute between those who subscribed to the Scotist view and Thomists who assigned primacy to redemption from sin. In Lonergan's view, the entire dispute rested on logic and dueling definitions of the two types of end in question.

Not surprisingly, Lonergan commends the method articulated by Aquinas at the beginning of the *Pars Tertia*.³⁶ Forswearing speculation about the logically possible, Aquinas follows Scripture and the creed in

36. See Aquinas, *ST* III, q. 1, a. 2.

discerning the restoration of the human race as *de facto* the purpose of the incarnation, and he assigns Christ's incarnation as the means of redemption, the very modest necessity one might, in Thomas's day, ascribe to a horse if one wished to journey to another city. One might conceivably get there by other means, but none is better suited to the purpose. Aquinas's focal interest lies in discovering how the incarnation exhibits such *convenientia*, and so, he draws upon authoritative sources to assemble the multiple ways in which the incarnation functions both to promote the good and to remove evil. Lonergan will make this method his own although, as he notes, the question he addresses differs somewhat from Aquinas's. He seeks an imperfect, analogical understanding of not only the incarnation, but together with it, of the passion, death, and resurrection of Christ as well.

The thesis itself comprises two elements. It proposes that the Law of the Cross articulates how, through the incarnation, passion, death, and resurrection of Christ, the evils of the human race are transformed into a supreme good, and it develops the *convenientia* of this means of redemption by showing how it coheres with and exhibits the divine wisdom and goodness. In a preliminary exposition of the sense of the thesis, Lonergan refers back to the previous thesis where, having shown how Christ transformed the wicked deed of his persecutors into a satisfaction most acceptable to God, he had generalized that "a quasi-principle of transformation is to be acknowledged in the whole work of redemption"³⁷ and he had also asserted that "this same principle of transformation seems to be of the essence of redemption, which is nothing other than this, that from the evils he permits God makes a more excellent good."³⁸ Now, in Thesis 17, Lonergan identifies that principle of transformation as the Law of the Cross. He explains that, as a principle of transformation, the Law of the Cross unfolds in three steps: "in the first, moral evil issues in the evil of punishment. Next, there is the voluntary transformation of punishment into good.

37. Lonergan, *DVI*, 543.

38. *Ibid.*, 544.

Thirdly, there is the blessing of this transformation by God the Father.”³⁹

In a prenote, Lonergan brings the Aristotelean doctrine of the four causes to bear on the economy of salvation as a way of specifying the question with which the thesis deals. The material cause of the economy is “the human race, infected with original sin, burdened with actual sins, trapped in the punishments for sin, alienated from God, divided in itself both individually and socially.”⁴⁰ The final cause is twofold. The entire created universe has, as its extrinsic final cause, a universal good that is good by its essence, namely, God, while its intrinsic final cause is the order of the universe itself. In the actual order of things, however, God is not simply an extrinsic final cause, but communicates God’s own self to the creature, “substantially in the hypostatic union and accidentally in the uncreated gift of the Holy Spirit and in God’s self-gift to the blessed in heaven.”⁴¹ Hence, the formal cause of the economy of salvation is the whole Christ, head and members.

This leaves the fourth Aristotelean cause, the agency by which the form is induced in the matter. Christ is the agent of redemption. In the first ten theses of *De Verbo Incarnato*, Lonergan dealt with the hypostatic union, and in the following four theses, he expounded how Christ’s humanity was equipped for his redemptive task with grace, knowledge, and freedom. Now, having reviewed the scriptural data on redemption and the traditional doctrine of satisfaction in the previous two theses, Lonergan devotes his final thesis to an attempt to grasp how the agent of redemption, the incarnate Son of God, with supreme *convenientia*, induced the form of redemption by his suffering, dying, and rising from the dead.

The argument of the thesis begins by invoking Scripture as warrant for the first step of the Law of the Cross. In various passages, St. Paul affirms the universal fact of sin and describes the enslavement to sin of the carnal human being. The books of Genesis and Wisdom and St. Paul

39. Ibid., 556.

40. Ibid., 566.

41. Ibid., 567.

all posit death as the penalty for sin and trace the origin of both sin and its penalty to the devil and to Adam.

Scripture, likewise, bears witness to the second and third steps of the Law of the Cross. St. Paul testifies to the transformation of death brought about by Christ, the new Adam. Various texts affirm that Christ's death was purposeful—he died that he might rise—and that God rewarded his obedience by exalting him. This transformation of death came about not solely for Christ's sake, but for ours as well, and it won for us not only spiritual goods, but also the physical good of bodily resurrection. Thus, the transformation of death is shown forth in Christ both as an individual and as head of his body, the church. The Father raised him and established him in glory at his right hand, and through Christ's mediation, the Father grants the gifts of justification and forgiveness of sins that constitute redemption.

The Law of the Cross articulates how Christ, the agent of redemption, brought about the transformative effect that defined his mission. Sin incurs the penalty of death, but in embracing his death, Christ transformed it into an expression of love and obedience, and the Father blessed that transformed dying by raising Christ from the dead and exalting him. That same law of transformation, Lonergan continues, is operative in a variety of contexts: sacramental, moral, ascetical, and even, insofar as it extends to our hope of resurrection, physical. At the same time, the Law of the Cross is enjoined on us. Scripture bids Christians to love their enemies and to take up their cross daily; thus the death of Christ is proposed as an example for them to follow. Scripture warns that Christ's followers cannot evade the cross, but it also sets forth Christ's resurrection no less than his death as an example.

Hence, Lonergan concludes, the Law of the Cross is the law of redemption. It is not the kind of law that binds with logical or metaphysical necessity, nor the kind of law that the empirical natural sciences grasp. It is a law of the spiritual order, a law in accordance with which rational beings endowed with free will attain their proper end and that requires faith to be discerned. As such, the Law of the

Cross expresses the essence and intrinsic intelligibility of the redemption won by Christ and extended by Christ as head to his members who, conformed to him in his dying and rising, participate in his body.

Having proposed the Law of the Cross as the essence of redemption, Lonergan turns to the task of exhibiting its *convenientia*. Why was it fitting “that the Son of God should make his own the Law of the Cross?”⁴² Fittingness, Lonergan recalls, is a matter of coherence with the divine wisdom and goodness. God’s goodness is manifest in the charity of the Son, who chose to become like us in the incarnation and who, incarnate, offered himself for us out of love, so that we are not left to ourselves, but bear our cross as “co-associates of Christ, conformed to Christ, conjoined with Christ.” Christ’s charity manifests the charity of the Triune God, who loved us even when we were sinners. As for wisdom, it is implicit in charity inasmuch as the will is good to the extent that it follows the order of wisdom. The New Testament portrays divine wisdom as the mystery, the hidden plan of God now disclosed in Christ, and Augustine found it a mark of divine omnipotence and goodness that “he judged it better to bring good out of evil, than not to permit evil to exist.”⁴³

Lonergan brings his thesis to a close with two scholia. In the first, he returns to the question, debated since the Middle Ages, of the purpose of the incarnation. To resolve the question, he draws a distinction between particular goods and the good of order. Particular goods fulfill individual wants and needs, while the good of order obtains when the set of conditions for the regular and recurrent satisfaction of individual wants and needs is fulfilled. For Aquinas, the intrinsic end of the universe and the highest finite good that exists is the order of the universe, which participates in and represents the divine goodness better than any particular good. It follows that the good of order and particular goods are like apples and oranges; they cannot be compared. One particular good may be better than another, and likewise for goods

42. Lonergan, *DVI*, 579.

43. *Ibid.*, 584, citing Augustine, *Enchiridion*, c. 27.

of order, “[b]ut only those who are not too bright will ask whether a railroad is better than capitalism, or this professor better than the curriculum.”⁴⁴

Turning to the case at hand, Lonergan states that “redemption is the restoration of a fallen order,” and this is the primary purpose of the incarnation. It is within that order that Christ holds primacy as the cause of salvation, and the goods intended for Christ within that order excel all others, so that one may say “that the primary particular purpose of the incarnation was the good of Christ and its secondary particular purposes were the goods of others.”⁴⁵

The second, final scholion addresses the question of the cause of sin. Why, if all reality, everything that exists, is the product of God’s infallible knowledge, efficacious will, and irresistible action, is God not responsible for sin? Lonergan’s response ruminates on the traditional notion of moral evil as not simply the privation of a good, but specifically, an irrational privation. As such, sin lacks ontological truth and intrinsic intelligibility. If one could answer the question, why, one would not be dealing with sin. Furthermore, because it lacks intrinsic intelligibility, sin cannot find an explanation in terms of final, exemplary, or efficient causes. Thus, it issues neither from God ordering or not ordering, willing or not willing, doing or not doing anything. Sin is a surd.

This line of reflection, Lonergan observes, does not solve the so-called “problem of evil.” It does, however, serve to purge the mind of fallacies, and thus, to prove that the objection to God’s wisdom, omnipotence, and goodness based on the fact of evil fails. A clear grasp of the non-intelligibility of sin “proves nothing except that the objection does not prove its point.”⁴⁶ Some, however, will find such rarified reflection too abstruse. In that case, the scriptural narrative proves instructive when it assigns the origin of sin to the devil. This does not provide an ultimate explanation—one can always ask why God created the serpent—but it does serve to preserve God from

44. *Ibid.*, 588.

45. *Ibid.*, 589.

46. *Ibid.*, 592.

responsibility for the existence of sin. Without clarity on that point, one is likely to confuse the roles of the Father and Judas, into whom the devil entered, in the passion and death of Christ, and, Lonergan adds, it must be feared that those who fail to make the distinction, “when they extol the excellence of the cross, not only imitate Christ in bearing the cross but also follow the Pharisees and Pilate in imposing it on others.”⁴⁷ On that cryptic and dyspeptic note, Lonergan’s manual concludes.

It is noteworthy and significant that the order of the concluding three theses of *De Verbo Incarnato* differs from that of the lengthy, unfinished supplement *De Redemptione*. The latter work began with preliminary chapters on good and evil and on divine justice. Its third chapter, on the death and resurrection of Christ, covered the same scriptural material as Thesis 15 of the manual. In the next chapter, along with articles on the meaning, mystery, and justice of the Cross, Lonergan devoted nine pages to the Law of the Cross. There followed a fifth chapter, on satisfaction, corresponding to Thesis 16 of the manual, and a final chapter on the effects of the redemption. When the manual devotes to the Law of the Cross a separate, and indeed, the final thesis, it accords the Law of the Cross a prominence it did not receive in the supplement. As we remarked above, with this order, the manual moves from the *vetera* of tradition expressed first in Scripture and then in satisfaction theory to something new, a proposal for a single systematic understanding that embraces not simply the incarnation, nor simply the passion, but the incarnation, passion, death, and resurrection of Christ.

Besides this change of order, within the manual, Lonergan leaves dangling a tantalizing loose end. In his thesis on satisfaction, we saw, he lays out how Aquinas integrated Anselm’s proposal with an earlier tradition that acknowledged that in some sense, in undergoing the passion, Christ had suffered the penalty for sin. Aquinas, Lonergan showed, found a place for that tradition within his version of satisfaction theory without distorting Anselm’s notion into a theory

47. *Ibid.*, 593.

of penal substitution. In the course of that analysis, Lonergan remarks that “we shall leave the general problem of integration to the next thesis.”⁴⁸ There, the matter ends, as far as the manual goes. At no point does Lonergan explain in what “the general problem of integration” consists, nor does the following thesis, on the Law of the Cross, so much as mention it.

That, of course, raises a question. What is “the general problem of integration,” and how does the proposal of Thesis 17, that the Law of the Cross articulates the essence of redemption, resolve it? Possibly the answer lies in the scope of Thesis 17. Whereas the previous thesis had expatiated on the meaning of satisfaction as an apt analogy for understanding the redemptive significance of the passion, Thesis 17 aims more broadly, offering a single act of understanding that embraces the incarnation, passion, and resurrection of Christ. Perhaps that move from multiplicity to unity is Lonergan’s response to the general problem of integration.

This surmise, however, enjoys only a limited plausibility. First, it fails to take into account the character of the particular problem of integration with which Thesis 16 had dealt. Anselm had achieved a systematic-theoretic understanding of redemption through the incarnation and death of Christ, but he had failed to advert to a tradition, articulated on the level of symbolic consciousness, that in saving us by his passion, Christ had endured the penalty for sin. Thomas, on Lonergan’s reading in Thesis 16, had wielded Aristotelean hylomorphism to incorporate that tradition into his version of satisfaction theory—Christ’s enduring the penalty for sin constituted the material principle of satisfaction—and thus, resolve the particular problem of integration the existence of that earlier tradition posed.

Those features of the particular problem of integration dealt with in Thesis 16 suggest that the general problem of integration involves more than a matter of breadth and scope. It too involves transposing traditional material into a new context. We noted that in dealing with Scripture and satisfaction in Theses 15 and 16, Lonergan had covered

48. Lonergan, *DVI*, 521.

the *vetera* of the tradition on the redemption, whereas in Thesis 17, he was offering something new. Lonergan himself provides grounds for recognizing that this progression from the *vetera* to a *novum* was wholly deliberate on his part. In the epilogue to his investigation of *Verbum: Word and Idea in Aquinas*, he situates his endeavor within the context of Leo XIII's mandate in the encyclical *Aeterni Patris*. In appropriating Aquinas for the contemporary church, Leo wrote, Catholic scholars were to "enlarge and complete the old with the new (*vetera novis augere et perficere*)."⁴⁹ This mandate, as Lonergan wrote in the epilogue, entailed two distinct tasks. One first had to determine what the *vetera* really were, a matter for historical investigation of the sort that engaged Lonergan in his *Verbum* study, and only then, would one be in a position to transpose and develop the old to meet the exigencies of a new and different context.

Theology in a New Context

Insight represents Lonergan's transposition of the account of knowing that he had discovered in *Verbum* to the modern context, but *De Verbo Incarnato* presents more of a compromise.⁵⁰ In the latter work, we have seen, Lonergan contented himself with operating within the conventions of the neoscholastic manual while enlarging his theses with prenotes and scholia in which he could address philosophical and historical issues pertinent to the matter at hand. Looking back not many years later, he remarked that the text "belongs to a period in which the situation I was in was hopelessly antiquated, but had not yet been demolished—it has since been demolished."⁵¹ In that former situation, the professor of dogmatic theology was expected to command his field with the omniscience of a Renaissance *uomo universale*.⁵² Underlying that expectation was the conviction that

49. Lonergan, *Verbum*, 222. The phrase occurs in paragraph 24 of the encyclical, issued Aug. 4, 1879.

50. Frederick M. Crowe offers the image of "the shifting battle front of trench warfare" as a metaphor for Lonergan's development and suggests that Lonergan's Latin textbooks represent a "delayed sector" within that context. Crowe, *Christ and History*, 14.

51. Philip McShane, "Interview with Fr. Bernard Lonergan, S. J.," *The Clergy Review* XVI (1971): 414.

52. Lonergan, "The Response of the Jesuit as Priest and Apostle in the Modern World, *A Second Collection*, eds. William F. J. Ryan and Bernard J. Tyrell (Philadelphia: Westminster Press, 1974), 182.

dogmatic theses articulated divinely revealed truth. Truth, however, enjoyed both permanence and universality. Hence, as Vincent of Lérins's dictum put it, dogmatic theology dealt with "what was proclaimed always, everywhere, and by all." Given the theologian's possession of that truth in faith, it seemed obvious that the theologian would be "equally at home in the Old and New Testaments, in the Greek and Latin Fathers, in the writings of medieval, Renaissance, and more recent theologians."⁵³

That expectation has been proved ill-founded in face of the explosion of modern exegetical and historical scholarship. Vincent of Lérins's dictum falls to the wayside when John Henry Newman discovers the fact of development in Christian doctrine and when Adolf von Harnack writes a five-volume history detailing that development. Furthermore, where the dogmatic theologian appealed directly to the words and deeds of Christ recounted in the Gospels as warrant for his theses, those words and deeds now appear often enough as expressions of the theology of the evangelist who penned them, while the interpretation of that theology has itself become an ongoing process. The task of interpretation extends as well to the dogmatic theologian's other authoritative sources. The simple repetition of classical conciliar formulae of faith now risks conveying a meaning different from, even opposed to, that originally intended. As a practical matter, the advent and progress of critical historical scholarship has produced an endlessly rising flood of specialized interpretive and historical studies of the monuments of the Christian tradition. Between the dogmatic theologian and his authoritative sources, these now stand as a seemingly impenetrable barrier. Given this state of affairs, Lonergan observes that "the old-style dogmatic theologian has simply become obsolete."⁵⁴ This summary judgment, we should note, applies to Theses 15 and 17 of *De Verbo Incarnato*. There, following the lead of Aquinas, Lonergan had found it sufficient for the instruction of his students to simply adduce scriptural citations as warrant for the elements of

53. Lonergan, "Theology in its New Context," *A Second Collection*, 59.

54. Lonergan, "Revolution in Catholic Theology," *A Second Collection*, 232.

his synthetic statement of the New Testament doctrine of redemption in Thesis 15 and for each member of the three-step principle of transformation that comprised the Law of the Cross in Thesis 17. That procedure may have been rhetorically effective in the setting of a Roman seminary, but it ignored the hermeneutical and historical issues raised by such a direct appeal to Scripture.

The proliferation and ongoing character of exegetical and historical scholarship signals a more profound reason for the obsolescence of neoscholastic dogmatic theology. That theology functioned within what Lonergan has termed a classicist understanding of culture. On that understanding, Western culture enjoyed normative status. The classical literary authors of Greece and Rome, joined by a select few representatives of the European vernacular, represented the highest achievements of the human spirit. In addition, the medieval schoolmen drew from the heritage of ancient Greece a perennial philosophy. That philosophy yielded a certain, scientific grasp of the necessary causes operative in a universe of stable, unchanging essences. Divine revelation established the one true religion. Compared to these riches, all other societies fell short. Other cultures were inferior, even barbaric, and their religions superstitious or the work of demons. The immortal works of art and literature, the perennial philosophy founded on unchanging truth, and the true religion of Christendom constituted a norm to which all cultured persons were to aspire.

In Lonergan's reading, the classicist understanding of culture continued to inform the self-understanding of the Catholic Church from the seventeenth century, when its theology shifted from a systematic to a dogmatic paradigm, until well into the twentieth century. Yet, at the same time that Catholic theology was taking its dogmatic turn, Western culture saw two developments that would undermine the classicist ideal and usher in modernity. Toward the end of the seventeenth century, natural science broke free of its metaphysical tutelage to become empirical. Aristotle's four causes no longer provided the analytic tools with which to glean the understanding of necessary causes that constituted scientific

knowledge. Natural science became a matter of mathematically formalizing the observation of empirical data, of generating hypothetical understandings of the immanent intelligibility of those data, and of devising experiments through which those hypotheses could be verified. Verified hypotheses yielded classical laws, and these called forth the complement of statistical analyses seeking to determine the probability of the occurrence of the conditions under which classical laws would in fact be operative. Through all of this, the stable universe of unchanging essences vanished in favor of an evolving, dynamically developing universe ruled by emergent probability.⁵⁵ To that universe, there corresponds a scientific practice that is itself dynamically developing, so that at any moment one can claim, not certain knowledge of necessary causes, but only the best scientific understanding currently available.⁵⁶

Modernity, in Lonergan's view, rests on a second pillar as well. In a development parallel to that by which the natural sciences became empirical, so also has the understanding of human reality that dominates modern Western culture.⁵⁷ An empirical apprehension of human reality pays full heed to the differences from which the notion of a timeless human nature abstracts. When one turns from the abstract to the concrete, the differences deemed accidental from the abstract viewpoint assume decisive significance. Human reality is constituted on the individual level through the process by which one negotiates the realm of meaning and value, and those constitutive elements are made available through the culture in which one participates. Cultures themselves vary notably from place to place and over time. On both levels, the individual and the cultural, an empirical approach reveals the historicity of human reality. Individuals forge their identity in an ongoing process, and the cultures that condition that process are themselves subject to variation and development. For Lonergan, the concomitant developments of the empirical natural

55. Lonergan, *Insight*, 126–62.

56. Lonergan, "Aquinas Today: Tradition and Innovation," *A Third Collection: Papers by Bernard J. F. Lonergan*, S. J., ed. Frederick E. Crowe, S. J. (New York/Mahwah: Paulist, 1985), 48.

57. Lonergan, "Revolution in Catholic Theology," *A Second Collection*, 232–34.

sciences and historical consciousness have conspired to generate a new cultural context, modernity, and it is this new context that poses the general problem of integration to which Lonergan alluded in Thesis 16 of *De Verbo Incarnato*, and which he promised, apparently without following through, that the following thesis on the Law of the Cross would address.

Lonergan's analyses of classicist culture and its concomitant dogmatic style of theology appeared only after, as he saw it, that context had been demolished. Yet, his critique was, by no means, simply *post factum*, a matter of hindsight. Rather, as we have seen, the challenges of modernity had engaged him from early in his student days. Dissatisfaction with the Suarezian epistemology of the scholastic manuals had led him to turn to Newman, Plato, Augustine, and eventually, in the *Verbum* articles, to a post-Kantian appropriation of Aquinas's cognitional theory that equipped him to meet the crisis of the objectivity of meaning and value precipitated by the emergence of modernity. On the basis of that rediscovery of Aquinas, he was enabled in *Insight* to conduct a critical appropriation of modern mathematics, physics, psychology, and sociology that preserved the genuine achievements of the classical past, fully appreciated the undeniable advances of modernity, and liberated the latter from the distortions arising from unexamined and mistaken philosophical assumptions. His experience teaching high school in Montreal during the Great Depression led him to recognize the pervasive influence of the economic sector of society and the need for an ethics founded on the intrinsic dynamics of that sector. As a young student of theology in Rome, he had begun to search for an understanding of the church's redemptive mission in the context of historical reality.

Hence, even as he assumed the role of a professor of dogmatic theology, Lonergan was keenly aware of the new context that rendered that mode of theological practice inadequate. If the genre of the dogmatic treatise was nonetheless mandatory, he could, at most, only compromise with that requirement within his own dogmatic manuals without contravening it. He found greater freedom, however, in the

materials he prepared to supplement those manuals, as well as in the doctoral seminars and summer workshops and courses he conducted while on the faculty at the Gregorianum. Thus, with regard to the supplements, we saw that he devoted one to resolving the wholly modern issue of Christ's human consciousness. His unpublished supplement on the redemption sought to set that doctrine within a new horizon by giving an account of the historical causality of Christ.⁵⁸ At the same time, the question of theological method had arisen for him in the course of his study of Aquinas on grace and freedom, and he had originally intended it as the goal of *Insight*, foreshortening and rounding that work off for practical reasons.⁵⁹ At the Gregorianum, he offered several doctoral seminars on theological method, and already in the first of these, in 1959, the "problema historicitatis" claimed his attention.⁶⁰

Modernity, as Lonergan views it, is founded on the differentiation of the empirical natural sciences and on the worldview of emergent probability that they yield, and on the rise of historical consciousness. The latter generates the dual problems of a hermeneutics that can yield understanding of the monuments of the past and a praxis whereby human beings can assume responsibility for the history they create. Modernity thus constitutes a new context that sets a general problem of integration for theology. In *De Verbo Incarnato*, Lonergan promises that Thesis 17, in which he proposes the Law of the Cross as the essence of redemption, will respond to that problem. Yet, in formulating the thesis, he resorts to the standard procedures of the dogmatic manual. This raises a large question. How does Lonergan's proposal of the Law of the Cross engage the problem of integration? Then, on the terms in which the thesis is couched, further questions ensue. How does Christ, the agent of salvation, induce the form which specifies redemption?

58. The final chapter of "De Redemptione" deals with social and historic agents and with the historic role of Christ in human history.

59. Lonergan, "Insight Revisited," *A Second Collection*, 268.

60. "De Intellectu et Methodo," *Early Works on Theological Method 2*, Collected Works of Bernard Lonergan 23, trans. Michael G. Shields, eds. Robert M. Doran and H. Daniel Monsour (Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 2013), 39–43. In the fall semester of the same year, he offered a seminar entitled "De systemate et historia," now published in the same volume of the collected works, pp. 230–313.

What is the reality to which the religious term “sin” refers, and how does the Law of Cross function in the remedy for that reality?

A Theology of History

If the dogmatic thesis provided too narrow a scope for addressing questions such as these, in other works spanning the length of his career, Lonergan provides material for coming to terms with them. We have seen that in response to the situation of the world in which he found himself when, in 1933, he arrived in Italy to begin his theological studies, Lonergan undertook to work out what he then referred to as a “metaphysics of history.” Having researched the essays that document that effort, Michael Shute concludes that “in the period prior to the completion of his doctoral work at the Gregorian, Lonergan had developed a theory of history that represents a permanent feature of his thought.”⁶¹ Lonergan himself confirms Shute’s finding in a paper prepared for the 1973 meeting of the Jesuit Philosophical Association, when he recalls that “[i]t was about 1937-38 that I became interested in a theoretical analysis of history.”⁶²

His analysis, he goes on to explain, employed “the model of a threefold approximation.” He offers Newton’s theory of planetary motion as an example of such a model. In Newton’s theory, a first approximation of planetary motion derives from the first law of motion, according to which, bodies in motion continue to move in a straight line with a constant velocity unless some interfering factor intervenes. Planets do not, however, move in a straight line. Gravitational attraction between the sun and the planets interferes with the effect of the first law of motion, and so, there results, in a second approximation, the elliptical motion of the planets. Finally, because the planets also exert gravity on one another, their ellipses are perturbed, and with this third approximation, one arrives at an account of the manner in which the planets actually move.

Turning to his own “rather theological analysis of human history,”

61. Shute, *The Origins of Lonergan’s Notion of the Dialectic of History*, 173.

62. Lonergan, “*Insight Revisited*,” 271.

Lonerger identifies as his first approximation “the assumption that men (*sic*) always do what is intelligent and reasonable,” from which would result “an ever increasing progress.” Yet, just as obvious as the fact that the planets do not move in a straight line is the shadow side of human history. Besides progress, there is decline. Lonergan derives a second approximation to the course of history by introducing into his theory “the radical inverse insight that men (*sic*) can be biased, and so unintelligent and unreasonable in their choices.” Decline is not, however, the whole story. Christian faith finds firm grounds for hope in God’s goodness, and so, Lonergan completes his theory with a third and final dynamic, namely, “the redemptive process resulting from God’s gift of his grace to individuals and from the manifestation of his love in Christ Jesus.”⁶³

For Lonergan, just as the motion of the planets finds its explanation in the interaction among the first law of motion, the gravitational attraction between sun and planet, and the gravitational attraction among the planets, so also can human history be understood through the interplay of the dynamics of progress, decline, and redemption. This, in brief, is the theory of history at which he arrived in the course of his theology studies in Rome and it remained, as Shute noted, a constant feature of his thought thereafter. In the interview just quoted, Lonergan goes on to lay out how the theory functioned in *Insight*.

The theory also features large in the first supplement he composed upon arriving at Rome as a professor at the Gregorianum, *De ratione convenientiae*. Lonergan wrote *De ratione convenientiae* in 1953–54, when he was lecturing on Charles Boyer’s manual in his Christology course. In the supplement, having explained in depth the notion of *convenientia* and how it functions in Aquinas’s method to develop the intelligibility of the truths of faith, he turns to the particular question of the *convenientia* of the incarnation. He observes that Boyer offers numerous reasons why the incarnation, while not necessary, is fitting. He then offers a comment with which he leaps beyond the limits of the neoscholastic thought-world of the manuals:

63. Lonergan, “*Insight Revisited*,” 271–72.

This topic can be treated more systematically, since the reasons for things are found more fully in the order of the universe, and indeed, as far as human affairs are concerned, in the historical order of the universe.⁶⁴

We have seen how, in his Christology, Lonergan had employed Aquinas's systematic construction of the order of the universe to sublimate the scholastic debate between Thomists and Scotists on the motive of the incarnation. Thomas had not, of course, conceived the order of the universe in historical terms, and with the comment just cited, Lonergan signals that he is embarking upon a *novum*, a transposition of Aquinas's construct in an historical key. He will put the theory of history at which he had arrived during his student days to work as a framework for determining the *convenientia*, the intrinsic intelligibility, of the incarnation.

That theory, as he now articulates it, discerns three principles operative in the course of history: "our intellectual nature, the defectible human will, and the help of a merciful God."⁶⁵ These principles, in turn, generate a series of questions that, in a manner similar to Newton's three approximations, constitute a heuristic for a comprehensive theological understanding of the concrete unfolding of human events. As Lonergan articulates them the relevant questions are:

(1) What would human history be like if every human being always followed the dictates of reason? (2) How is the course of human history changed as a result of the fact that people choose to act contrary to the dictates of reason? (3) How can the reign of sin be destroyed and the human race brought back to living in conformity with reason?⁶⁶

In developing his response to these questions, Lonergan establishes the full context that determines the meaning of his proposal that the Law of the Cross articulates the essence of redemption.

64. Lonergan, *The Notion of Fittingness*, 507.

65. *Ibid.*

66. *Ibid.*

**“Our Intellectual Nature,” “The Dictates of Reason,”
and Generalized Empirical Method**

According to Lonergan’s first approximation, history would follow a course of unending progress if, in accordance with “our intellectual nature,” human beings always and everywhere followed “the dictates of reason.” Lonergan couches this first approximation in the language of scholasticism. In this context, human beings are defined as rational animals, distinguished from other animals by souls possessing the faculties of intellect and will, and human goodness finds its measure in the conformity of will to right reason. This metaphysically based scholastic account of human nature with its faculty psychology provided the *lingua franca* of the academic world within which Lonergan presented *De ratione convenientiae*. Already in the *Verbum* articles, however, he had penetrated to the underlying but unthematized operations of cognitional consciousness upon which Aquinas’s rendering of that metaphysical account rested. In this manner, he was enabled, as Fergus Kerr recognizes, to retrieve the genuine position of Aquinas on human knowing,⁶⁷ and with this retrieval, he put paid to the distorted conceptualist account that dominated the scholasticism of the day. That latter account ignored the data of consciousness, and specifically, the conscious act of understanding. In the conceptualist account, knowledge resulted from the operation of what Lonergan dubbed a “metaphysical sausage machine.” That machine began its operation by slicing a *species* off from a phantasm. There followed a mysterious, unconscious process, at the other end of which out popped an abstract universal concept.⁶⁸

In contrast to this conceptualist distortion, Lonergan discovered in Aquinas the metaphysical account of a dynamically ordered complex of conscious intentional operations. That discovery was hard-won. Negatively, it entailed “the task of detaching from Thomist interpretation the endless tendrils of an ivy mantle woven by

67. F. Kerr, *Twentieth Century Catholic Theologians* (Oxford: Blackwell, 2007), 119.

68. Lonergan, *Verbum*, 34; see idem, “The Subject,” *A Second Collection*, 74–75 and McShane, “An Interview with Bernard Lonergan,” *A Second Collection*, 222.

oversubtle metaphysicians and conceptualist gnoseologists.”⁶⁹ Positively, it required a massive, arduous development within Lonergan himself, the development that occurred through the “slow, repetitious labor” involved in reaching up to the mind of Aquinas, of coming to understand Aquinas’s written words by coming to understand as Aquinas understood.⁷⁰

That achievement was not an end in itself. Beyond understanding Aquinas, Lonergan wrote at the conclusion of his study, “one can aim at a transposition of his position to meet the issues of our own day.”⁷¹ Thus, straightaway upon completing his study of *Verbum*, Lonergan set himself to that work of transposition in *Insight*. At one level a study of methods in preparation for a consideration of method in theology,⁷² at the same time, and perhaps more fundamentally, the book is strategically designed to facilitate the self-appropriation of the reader as a knower. In *Insight*, Lonergan addresses three questions, and it is significant that he casts them in the first person. As he summarizes in an address to the American Catholic Philosophical Association, *Insight* invites the reader to ask “(1) What am I doing when I am knowing? (2) Why is doing that knowing? (3) What do I know when I do it?”⁷³

It is inquiry that sets one on the path to knowing, and the starting point of that path is experience. For Aristotle and Aquinas, famously, there is nothing in the intellect that is not first in the senses, and Lonergan follows their lead. Inquiry requires data, something to ask about, and those data are supplied, first of all, by the conscious activities that comprise experience in a narrow sense of the term, the activities that introduce sense impressions of various sorts—tastes, touches, smells, sights, etc.—into one’s stream of consciousness. Not every aspect of that stream attracts attention, but when, for one reason another, attention does bring something into focus, the process of

69. Lonergan, *Verbum*, 224.

70. *Ibid.*, 223.

71. *Ibid.*, 227.

72. “I worked at *Insight* from 1949 until 1953. During the first three years my intention was an exploration of methods generally in preparation for a study of the method of theology.” Lonergan, “*Insight* Revisited,” *A Second Collection*, 268.

73. Lonergan, “Philosophy and Theology,” *A Second Collection*, 269.

understanding takes its rise. In the first chapter of *Insight*, Lonergan draws upon the operations of mathematicians to help one recognize and distinguish in oneself the conscious operations by which one moves from data to understanding. Euclidean geometry offers perhaps the simplest instance. Seeking to understand what makes a circle a circle, for example, the geometer ponders the image of something round. She ignores the irrelevant aspects of the image, its color, or size, or thickness. Such abstraction sets the stage for the moment when wonder gives way to insight. She “gets it,” the penny drops, the light goes on. She grasps in the data an intelligible pattern of relations, and she follows up on this act of understanding by formulating what it is she has grasped in terms of center, circumference, and distance. Euclidean geometry serves for Lonergan to demonstrate clearly the preconceptual character of the act of understanding, the priority of that act to concept, and it illustrates as well how abstraction brings not an impoverishment, but rather, an enrichment of experience.

Mathematicians can give their imaginations free rein in positing or altering the postulates upon which their systems rest, and once this has been recognized, the possibility, and indeed, the fact of geometries other than Euclid’s follows. In addition, mathematics offers a further illustration of the relation of imaginal datum to insight. Whole systems can serve as a datum calling forth the insight that issues in a higher integration, in the manner in which algebra follows upon arithmetic or calculus upon algebra. In this discussion, Lonergan’s aim is not to instruct his reader in mathematics. He seeks to glean, from mathematics, examples that may enable the reader to experience for herself and recognize the occurrence of the act of understanding as the preconceptual grasp of an intelligible pattern in some datum of experience.

Understanding does not, however, complete the knowing process, and Lonergan follows Aquinas in locating that completion in the occurrence of a second type of insight, the type that issues in a judgment. To help his reader access the conscious operations that lead one beyond understanding to judgment, he turns in *Insight* from his

first chapter on mathematics to four more that explore the practice of physics. Physics seeks to explain natural phenomena, and in service of this aim, it defines its data with technical precision. Physicists speak not of relative warmth or coolness, but of temperature, not of heaviness or lightness, but of mass. Then, insight into the data thus formalized provides no more than hypotheses, intelligible patterns that may or may not be relevant to the data under investigation. Thus, as Aristotle had already acknowledged, beyond the question for understanding—what is it?—there emerges a further question—is it so?

The natural sciences are empirical, and physicists cannot rest content with hypotheses. As Lonergan blithely notes, insights are a dime a dozen. Physicists find themselves constrained to devise experiments with which to test the validity of their hypotheses. Some experiments pan out, while others do not, but in both cases, the experiment yields new data for further inquiry. The point, however, is to recognize the qualitatively different question that follows upon the act of understanding: is it so? That question sets in motion a new series of conscious operations. What guides the construction of an experiment is the effort to determine what conditions must obtain for the hypothesis to enjoy validity and to discover how to assemble evidence that manifests the fulfillment of those conditions. Judging the validity of an hypothesis requires one to first marshal, and then, weigh the relevant evidence, and the crucial moment occurs with an insight that grasps the sufficiency of the evidence. That insight grounds the judgment by which one pronounces the hypothesis as valid, as expressing with certitude, or with some degree of probability, a correct understanding of the data under investigation. With judgment one arrives at the truth about reality.

In *Insight*, Lonergan employs these forays into mathematics and physics as “five fingered exercises” through which one may appropriate the character of one’s knowing as comprising a dynamically ordered complex of quite distinct intentional activities.⁷⁴ Those activities that comprise experience in a narrow sense yield data,

74. Lonergan, “*Insight Revisited*,” *A Second Collection*, 269.

and they call forth a second series that enriches those data with an intelligible pattern of relations, while a third series determines the actual relevance of that pattern to the data at hand. Knowing, then, involves experience and understanding, and it comes to completion in judgment. Tutored by his early reading of Newman on the illative sense, Lonergan terms the object that judgment attains as “virtually unconditioned,” that is, a conditioned state of affairs whose conditions happen to be fulfilled. “Happen to be” is the key notion here. If the ideal of necessity bewitched both ancient and early modern notions of science, Lonergan’s account of knowing breaks that spell. God’s infinite freedom renders the universe wholly contingent in both the order of nature and the order of grace and redemption, and Lonergan’s account of human knowing fully honors that contingency. The process that leads beyond experience through understanding to judgment liberates one from the narrow strip of space and time of immediate experience. One takes one’s place in the real world not as it has to be, but as it happens to be, a world invested with meaning and value, the universe of being.

Lonergan’s concern in *Insight* centered primarily on knowing, but as his thought continued to develop, he reached toward a fuller, richer apprehension of the human reality within which knowing is achieved. From existentialism, he gleaned the insight that the rationality inherent in “our intellectual nature” is a project to be achieved rather than simply given. In various philosophers of the second phase of the Enlightenment—he invokes Kierkegaard, Schopenhauer, Nietzsche, Blondel, and the pragmatists—he discerns a grasp of the priority of praxis over theory. Marx had urged that the point of philosophy was to change reality, not merely know it. In a very different context, Cardinal Newman would propose a toast to the pope, but first of all, to conscience.

Already, in *Insight*, Lonergan had distinguished among various patterns of experience, patterns in which the stream of consciousness flows, among them the biological, the aesthetic, the intellectual, and the dramatic. In the latter, he wrote, one’s “first work of art is his own

living. The fair, the beautiful, the admirable is embodied in man in his own body and actions before it is given still freer realization in painting and sculpture, in music and poetry.”⁷⁵ Yet, having acknowledged the priority of the dramatic pattern in ordinary life, his interest lay elsewhere. Hence, he went on to consider the conditioning limits set upon the dramatic pattern by its organic substrate with its neural demand functions, the role of the human psyche in mediating those demand functions to consciousness, and the psychic aberrations that can distort the dramatic pattern. Through these considerations, which effected a critical appropriation of the depth psychology initiated by Freud, his aim was to exhibit once again the centrality of insight, the act of understanding, this time in the context of the therapeutic process.

If, in *Insight*, Lonergan bent his recognition of the dramatic pattern of consciousness to other purposes, in the post-*Insight* stage of his thought, what he comes to term “the existential subject” takes center stage. Among the products of cognition are judgments that affirm the possibility of various courses of action, and in responding to those possibilities, one both forges one’s own identity and makes what difference one will to the course of history. Cognitive self-transcendence places one in the world as it is, but Lonergan reserves the term real self-transcendence for the further process, whereby one constitutes both oneself, and, in whatever measure, history.

Judgments of possibility do not occur in a vacuum. They, and indeed, the whole series of intentional activities that Lonergan has been at pains to lead his reader recognize, occur in a context shot through with feeling. *Insight*, with its intense concentration on the cognitive, discussed feeling mainly from the viewpoint of how it can interfere with disinterested inquiry, and from that analysis, one may glean an impression of Lonergan as a thin-lipped intellectualist. As he moves beyond *Insight*, however, Lonergan comes to acknowledge that “feeling gives intentional consciousness its mass, momentum, drive, power.”⁷⁶

75. Lonergan, *Insight*, 210–11.

76. Lonergan, *Method in Theology*, 30.

Without exaggeration one might say that for Lonergan, feeling makes the world go around.

Among the feelings we experience, Lonergan follows Dietrich von Hildebrand in distinguishing some as intentional. On this topic, we may observe that Lonergan offers a highly compressed analysis. Indeed, each chapter of *Method in Theology* would lend itself to a book-length, pedagogically structured expansion, but only in the case of the first chapter has Lonergan provided the corresponding fuller exposition, in *Insight*. Lonergan quickly distinguishes intentional feelings from states, such as fatigue, or trends, such as hunger, in that while the latter can be experienced without their cause or goal being known, intentional feelings relate us to objects that are consciously apprehended and represented. Through intentional feelings, we are related to known objects. These objects, in turn, fall into two classes. Some strike us as agreeable and satisfying, or the opposite, and others embody genuine value. At times, the two coincide, but they need not.

Hence, when the apprehension through intentional feeling of an object joins with knowledge of a possible course of action through which that object may be attained, a further question arises: is it truly good? Intentional feeling of itself is ambiguous. The course of action toward which it inclines us may be merely satisfying. It may militate against the achievement of genuine value. Hence, even as rationality requires that one marshal and weigh the evidence before proceeding to a judgment of fact, so responsibility calls for the deliberation that moves beyond felt inclination to a judgment of value from which decision and action may proceed. Nor, we may note, do decision and action follow automatically from a correct judgment of value. Concretely, much depends on a process of moral development that involves a refinement of one's intentional feelings. Such development heads toward a deep-seated, habitual attunement to genuine value. Virtue comes into play to foster both the discernment of genuine value and the willingness necessary to move from value judgment to its implementation.

With this consideration of the existential subject, Lonergan

completes his account of what he calls transcendental or generalized empirical method. The account conceptualizes and formulates the invariant pattern of operations through which one constitutes one's own identity and contributes to the historical process. That pattern is transcendental, given with our humanity at all times and places. It generalizes empirical method, extending the field of data beyond the world of sense to attend to and appropriate one's experienced interior operations. Immanent to these operations are their criteria: attentiveness to relevant data, intelligence in understanding those data, reasonableness in proceeding to judge the correctness of one's understanding, and responsibility in arriving at and acting upon the judgments of value that guide one's living. These criteria constitute the measure of human authenticity so that, in both knowing the real and discerning the good, objectivity is the fruit of authentic subjectivity.

First Approximation: The Ideal Course of Human Progress

Lonerган employs the language of scholasticism when he proposes that history would consist in "the progressive actuation of human intellect" were everyone everywhere and at all times to "follow the dictates of reason." Set within the context of his fuller understanding of the human subject, it becomes evident that this first approximation to the actual course of history is reached by asking what would result were each of us entirely authentic, that is, entirely faithful to the exigencies of self-transcendence immanent to the unfolding of our humanity through experience, understanding, judgment, and responsibility. In response to that question, Lonergan derives from his account of transcendental method a basic unit of progress. He can then deploy that basic unit genetically to project the ideal lines along which civilization and its culture would advance.

The basic unit. Experience, understanding, judgment and responsibility form a circuit, and as the performance of that circuit recurs, it yields cumulative results. The empirical natural sciences provide a salient instance of a specialization of transcendental method determined by the single, if enormous, goal of understanding the

physical universe. That same method operates in the mundane arena of daily living. Experience and understanding of the situation in which one finds itself reveal possible courses of action through which the promise and challenges posed by the situation may be met. Discernment weighs the value of those possible courses of action, and if decision brings their execution, the circuit is complete. One then finds oneself in a new experiential situation, one modified by previous decision and action. One's concerns will again suggest further questions, leading to the discovery of new possibilities. Practical judgments again follow, and if they are translated into action, the circle takes another turn. The dynamics of the invariant structure of transcendental method yield the basic unit of a circle moving from experience through understanding, judgment, discernment, and execution into a progressively modified field of experience. With each turn of the circle, the wheel of progress rolls forward.

Civilization. In *Insight*, Lonergan draws a technical distinction between civilization and culture. Civilization develops in response to vital human needs for food, drink, shelter, and reproduction, while culture refers to the dimension of meaning and value that invests human living to render it human. At a primitive stage of civilization, a spontaneous intersubjectivity provides the bond of family and clan, as together, they face the problem of wresting sustenance from the environment. In response to that problem, skills develop along with a growing fund of knowledge. Hunters become familiar with the habitats and movements of their prey. Some become adept at devising weapons with which to facilitate the hunt. Gatherers acquire and pass on familiarity with the growth cycle of their nourishment. Within the group, different skills develop, and the bond of kinship ensures that all receive a share in the fruits of their development. That development is cumulative, and the growing fund of common sense that it comprises passes through family and clan from one generation to the next.

The ongoing development of skills and techniques introduces complexity into the social body. As skills become more specialized, a division of labor that assigns distinct tasks to different groups is

called forth. The exercise of the various skills requires that materials be procured, and, at the other end of the process, the share of the different groups in the fruits of labor has to be ensured. An economic system begins to function. In addition, the groups have to be staffed, and their mutual cooperation must be ensured. Persuasion and management are called for—a need met by some sort of political arrangement.

Thus, in order to meet the vital needs of human beings, there develop in dynamic interdependence, systems of technology, economics, and politics. When these systems succeed in ensuring a recurrent flow of particular goods throughout the social body, a distinct value, the good of order, is achieved. Furthermore, at a given point in the development and expansion of the social body, the social groupings within that body undergo a radical shift. They are no longer simply determined by the spontaneous intersubjectivity that gives strength to the ties of blood. The intervention of practical intelligence transforms them into a civil community determined by collaboration in maintaining and advancing the good of order.

Culture. Human beings do not merely live. They invest their living with meaning and value. If civilization functions to make human living possible, culture provides the medium in which the meaning and value that make that living human come to expression. Every society finds and expresses its humanity in a culture with artistic, ethical, and religious dimensions. For Lonergan, the values that render living human form a scale.⁷⁷ Beyond the vital values that inform the particular goods necessary for subsistence and beyond the good of order that ensures the availability of those goods, aesthetic values come into play to enhance the routines of subsistence with delight and wonder at in the sheer goodness of existence. The non-negotiable ontic value of persons founds an ethic, and, ultimately, the transcendent value that grounds all other values evokes the response of religion.

Meaning and value inform human living as human. Meaning, in turn, performs various functions. Through its cognitive function, meaning

77. Lonergan, *Method in Theology*, 31.

opens a path of liberation from the world of immediacy, the narrow strip of time and space to which the infant is confined. Meaning becomes efficient as practical intelligence transforms the environment in the process of civilizational advance. Where once they dwelled in caves, men and women become citizens of teeming cities. In a third function, meaning enters all social institutions and cultural forms as an intrinsic, constitutive element.

Like civilization, culture admits of progress. Language is invented, and its development provides a crucial medium in which the human capacity to discover meaning and value can be actualized. The invention of writing, in turn, decisively expands the availability of the expressions of achieved meaning and value across time and space. In a reflective movement, grammars and logics develop to guide the expression of meaning, while literature and the arts provide an arena in which to explore, extend, and refine the range of meaning and value that informs the life of the community.

Stages of meaning. Progress, both civilizational and cultural, occurs through a process of development in the human apprehension of meaning and value. In the history of the West, Lonergan discerns a series of distinct stages through which the human capacity to deal with meaning and value has advanced. Through that series, human understanding of the physical universe has expanded vastly, while clarity in grasping the values that evoke commitment has been greatly enhanced. Progress of the latter sort promotes human freedom in the fundamental project of self-transcendence. Lonergan follows this strand of progress as it has advanced through three stages: common sense, theory, and interiority. In this sequence, neither of the latter stages abrogates the achievement of what preceded it. Rather, each subsequent stage enriches the preceding and sets it in a new, fuller context. Once again, the basic unit of the circle of progress provides Lonergan's instrument of analysis.

At a first stage, human intelligence develops the dynamic complex of what Lonergan terms common sense, a growing fund of insights that equips human beings to deal with the practical, concrete problems of

living. Common sense can grow enormously sophisticated. It accounts not only for the survival of primitive societies, but also for the achievement of the ancient high civilizations with their technologies, economies, and politics. For all this possible sophistication, however, the apprehension of meaning and value at this stage remains fundamentally global, undifferentiated. Imagination and affectivity dominate to identify the values that feelings reveal with the things and occasions that evoke those feelings. Graphic pictures satisfy the need for explanation. Concrete symbols mediate the apprehension of meaning and value, and those symbols remain close to the level of experience, rich in image and affect, pre-logical. Lonergan places this realm of common sense and its symbolic mode of consciousness at the beginning of cultural development.

Symbolic consciousness does not lack insight into human meaning and value. What it does lack is self-awareness, and progress consists in the further development of consciousness by which self-awareness is attained, making possible a differentiated control of symbolically mediated meaning. The move to a stage of meaning beyond the potentialities of common sense unlocks a whole new world, the realm of theory. Lonergan finds that Aristotle made this move when, in his *Nichomachean Ethics*, he succeeded in formulating the universal definitions that Socrates had sought in vain.⁷⁸ Aristotle also drew the line that distinguishes theory from common sense in his *Posterior Analytics*, when he adverted to the difference between descriptive knowledge of things in relation to us and explanatory knowledge of things in their relations to one another.⁷⁹ Lonergan adduces as another instance of the emergence of the realm of theory the doctrinal process running from the New Testament through the patristic councils into the medieval *summae*.⁸⁰ Anselm, we have seen, found in the metaphysically articulated Augustinian-Platonic worldview, the framework for his theory of satisfaction, while Aquinas took Aristotle's *ordo disciplinae* as the organizing principle of the *Summa Theologiae*.

78. Lonergan, *Method in Theology*, 82.

79. Aristotle, *Posterior Analytics*, 71b-72a.

80. Lonergan, *Method in Theology*, 277.

Lonergan finds yet a third instance of the transition from common sense to theory in the shift, beginning in the seventeenth century, whereby the method of the natural sciences became empirical.

In each case, the turn to theory opens up a realm of meaning not accessible to common sense. The aim of common sense is immediate and practical, and so, it rightly views things as related to the needs and desires of the subject, individual or communal. Common sense manifests a structural egocentricity. Theory, however, involves a shift in perspective. The scientific enterprise, for example, takes as its ideal goal an understanding of things in their mutual relationships, independent of the needs and desires of the scientist. Scientists as a community commit themselves, not to the immediately practical or workable, but to a cumulative understanding of their field of data. The detached, disinterested desire to know drives science beyond the concerns of common sense into the world of theory.⁸¹

In whatever context it occurs, the breakthrough to the realm of theory produces a state of disequilibrium. The attempt to live in two worlds generates a tension. One is at home in the world of common sense, the familiar world of things as they impinge on one's experience, but the theoretic differentiation of consciousness places one in a rarified world that runs counter to one's familiar experience. Must one doubt that the sun rose this morning, that the moon waxes and wanes in the course of a month? Is this desk, to use another of Lonergan's examples, solid beneath my fist, or is it, as the physicist Eddington had it, mostly empty space?⁸² The move into the world of theory can dislocate one. One's psyche is attuned to the world of common sense, one's intellect thrusts one into the world of theory. The question arises: which world is real? Through this disequilibrium, what Lonergan terms a critical exigence emerges. One must determine what reality is, in what objectivity and truth consist. Only by resolving these questions can one resolve the tension between common sense and theory.

Premature resolutions are, of course, possible. Socrates's fellow

81. See Lonergan, *Insight*, 209–10, on the intellectual pattern of experience.

82. Lonergan, *Method in Theology*, 84.

citizens removed the disturbance and discomfort his questions roused—by removing him. Common sense can dismiss theory as “just theory,” impractical, and hence, negligible. Conversely, discovery of the world of theory can so inflate its initiates that, believing themselves in possession of the really real, they condemn the simplicity of the general populace.

A path to honoring the validity of both common sense and theoretical knowledge opens up when one adverts to the fact that neither the world of common sense nor the world of theory is simply given. Access to both worlds lies through the operations of conscious intentionality. The key to resolving the tension between them lies in their common point of origin. The critical exigence thus opens onto the world of human interiority, the world of the conscious subject and his or her conscious operations. The basic circle functions in this context also. Scientific method formalizes the operation of the circle, but philosophic method, as Lonergan envisages it, employs a technique of self-appropriation to reflectively duplicate the elements of the circle. This philosophic inquiry shifts attention from the objects of conscious intentionality to the subject who does the intending.⁸³ The outcome, we have seen, is Lonergan’s account of transcendental or generalized empirical method, an account that reveals the criteria of reality, truth, and objectivity operative, although with differing goals, in the worlds of both common sense and theory.

Thus, in one line of development, cultural progress moves out from the compact density of symbolic consciousness as successive differentiations unlock the worlds of first theory and then interiority. Lonergan employs the control of meaning that these developments of consciousness afford to draw the line between lower and higher cultures.⁸⁴ Lower cultures remain within the bounds of common sense, limited to a symbolic apprehension of the human good. The higher culture of the West, we have seen, has passed through two stages. Intoxicated by its own achievement, it became classicist, conceiving

83. *Ibid.*, 22–23.

84. *Ibid.*, 86–96.

the system within which it explicated its control of meaning as immutable, the apex of intellectual achievement.⁸⁵ The advent of historical consciousness, however, is ushering classicism out. Historical thinking recognizes the relativity of every expression of meaning and adverts to the incompleteness of all human knowing. Such insights have a sobering effect, and they can deepen the urgency attending human responsibility for the course of history that falls increasingly subject to human making. “The challenge of history,” Lonergan writes, “is for man (*sic*) progressively to restrict the realm of chance or fate or destiny and progressively to enlarge the realm of conscious grasp and deliberate choice.”⁸⁶

Second Approximation: “Our Defectible Will” and the Reign of Sin

Lonergan draws from his account of generalized empirical method a basic unit from which he can project the ideal lines of progress in actualizing the human good, and the progress resulting from the deployment of that basic unit constitutes the first vector operative in his theology of history. Lonergan does not, however, subscribe to the liberal myth of automatic progress.⁸⁷ The ideal would be actual only “if every man always followed the dictates of right reason,” but as a matter of fact, no one responds to the exigencies of self-transcendence with perfect fidelity. To move from the abstractness of his genetic account to a closer approximation to the actual unfolding of history, Lonergan turns to what he calls a dialectical method.⁸⁸ The aim of this procedure is to first identify the source or root of infidelity to our own humanity, and then, to trace the distorting effect this introduces into the course of history. By performing this analysis, Lonergan secures the meaning of the theological category, sin, and establishes a basis

85. See Lonergan, “The Transition from a Classicist World View to Historical Mindedness,” *A Second Collection*, 1–9.

86. Lonergan, *Insight*, 253.

87. See *Ibid.*, 711.

88. See *Ibid.*, 242, 268–69, 446–47 and Robert M. Doran, *Theology and the Dialectics of History* (Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 1990), 64–92.

upon which a heuristic anticipation of the structure of his third historical vector, redemption, can be derived.

In his doctoral dissertation, Lonergan took note of Saint Thomas's sober realism with regard to human nature.⁸⁹ Thomas, working within a metaphysical framework that measured perfection by the ratio of act to potency, ranked human beings lowest in the hierarchy of intelligent beings. The spiritual powers of the human being exist at birth in a state of potency comparable to the prime matter that medieval thought consigned to the lowest conceivable grade of being. To make matters worse, human beings have to actuate this potency as incarnate beings subject to the irrational impulses of the passions. Under these conditions, lapses become inevitable.

Lonergan makes this sober vision his own, but he does not repeat the Thomist analysis in terms of grades of being and a faculty psychology. Rather, he seeks to integrate Thomas's insight with contemporary resources. Some forms of modern philosophy have brought the historicity of human existence into clear focus, and developmental theories in psychology, particularly as worked out by the so-called "Third Force," complement this accent.⁹⁰ Sociological analyses of the processes by which human beings construct their world likewise prove relevant. By incorporating Thomas's insights with resources such as these, Lonergan elaborates his own view of the precariousness of human development.

Lonergan presents human nature as a dynamically structured project of self-transcendence. The structure of the human being comprises a series of distinct, relatively autonomous sub-systems. Thus, physics, chemistry, and biology, each account for different aspects of the human being, and these aspects provide the material basis for psychic, intelligent, moral, and religious activity. Each sub-system is distinct, yet all are interlocked in ascending fashion. If the dynamics of that structure allowed Lonergan to project a genetic account of human progress, that account was ideal and abstract. It

89. Lonergan, *Grace and Freedom*, 42ff.

90. Lonergan, *Method in Theology*, 67–70.

presupposed total efficiency in the process by which lower systems are sublated into a higher synthesis. In the actual order, such total efficiency does not exist. There exists a tension between the relative autonomy of the various sub-systems and the dynamic of higher synthesis. Hence, scientists find it necessary to complement the universality of classical laws with statistical schemes of probability.⁹¹ No chemical reaction, for example, exploits all the elements involved, and biological entities produce material waste.

The inertial tendency of lower systems becomes acutely significant for human development at the juncture of the psychic and intelligent levels. Lonergan takes this fact as the starting point for the analysis of the second vector in his theology of history. Introducing this second approximation to the course of history, he writes that “social development would be simply a matter of intellectual development, if the human psyche were without its contribution.”⁹² All properly human activity begins at the level of experience, that is, with the cluster of activities that render one conscious. Although consciousness may not be initially focused, it comes to assume a particular shape under the selective influence of the individual’s concerns.⁹³ By determining which elements of experience are to receive attention, one’s concerns set the limit to the extent of one’s world. They set the range of possible objects of judgment or commitment to which one may advert.

The psyche can block or distort human development on two counts. First, the psyche mediates between the biological and intelligent dimensions of our humanity. Neural demands transmit organic needs, but in order to be fulfilled, these demands require the symbolizing activity of the psyche. Only if the psyche provides appropriate images linked with corresponding affects can the organic needs of an

91. See Lonergan, *Insight*, chapters 2 and 4.

92. Lonergan, *Insight*, 620.

93. Lonergan, *Topics in Education: The Cincinnati Lectures of 1959 on the Philosophy of Education*, Collected Works of Bernard Lonergan 10, Robert M. Doran and Frederick E. Crowe, eds. (Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 1988), 83.

individual enter consciousness, attract attention, and find satisfaction.⁹⁴

This mediating function of the psyche founds the possibility of neurosis. It may happen, for example, that in response to some traumatic event, the image and affect that mediate a significant need become split. When such a split occurs, the affect may then migrate to attach itself to an incongruous object. This loss of the appropriate image precludes the occurrence of the insight that would lead to satisfaction of the need.⁹⁵ Thus, the individual becomes condemned to fruitless symbolic activity in the effort to meet a felt, but disguised and unfulfilled need. By responding to a traumatic event with a repression of this sort, the psyche distorts the flow of consciousness and warps the process of development at the basic level of experience.

There is a second manner in which the psyche can interfere with development. As mediator of the biological dimension to consciousness, the psyche responds to stimuli. It is spontaneously extroverted, and hence, it fosters a tendency to identify as real whatever is contacted through the senses,⁹⁶ and as good whatever evokes feelings of desire.⁹⁷ Human beings develop according to a definite rhythm in which physical growth dominates the initial period, and so, the criteria of reality and value founded on the extroverted character of the psyche that govern the world of the infant tend to establish themselves firmly and to perdure even as one acquires the skills with which to enter and negotiate the world invested with meaning and value.

The psyche plays a permanent, necessary, and positive role in structuring human experience. At the same time, its spontaneous extroversion runs counter to the human drive, of itself unlimited, toward being and value. This tension between the psychic dimension of our humanity and the properly human realm of intellectual, moral, and religious activity fosters a drag on one's responsiveness to the

94. Lonergan, *Insight*, 211.

95. *Ibid.*, 216–17.

96. *Ibid.*, 207.

97. *Ibid.*, 238.

exigencies of the latter. Is the real simply what is already out there to be contacted through our senses, or is it to be identified with what judgments about the correctness of the intelligible patterns one discerns in the data of experience reveal? Is the good simply whatever satisfies desire, or is it actualized by deciding and acting upon judgments that subject the ambiguity of our desires to discernment, distinguishing authentic value from mere satisfaction? The spontaneous extroversion of the psyche would bind us to the former set of criteria of the real and the good, and the interference it introduces in this way into the project of self-transcendence generates three factors that Lonergan calls biases. Having located the tension that is their source, he proceeds with his dialectical account by tracing the cumulative effects of their interference with the dynamics of progress in the human good.

Individual Bias. Individual bias is the first of these factors.⁹⁸ When the needs and desires of an individual emerge spontaneously on the level of experience, they carry with them a charge of psychic force, and this force can make their demand for satisfaction imperious. It invests them with an aura of reality denser than the needs of others or the common good of society can muster. The psychic force that attaches to one's own needs and desires introduces a bias in the development of the individual.

This bias does not operate with the force of a determinism. Human beings are essentially free, oriented to the good in an unlimited manner. Left unchecked, however, individual bias leads into egoism. The egoistic individual commits him or herself to the project of fulfilling his or her individual needs and desires. Yet, one cannot rely on simple spontaneity to execute that project; it will require that one develop considerable ingenuity and intellectual sophistication. In this manner, egoism differs from the spontaneity that provides its basis, and that difference renders egoism ultimately incoherent. While egoism fosters intellectual development, at the same time, it posts a limit to that development. For the whole project of egoism raises

98. Lonergan, *Insight*, 244–47.

further questions for the individual. Is such fulfillment truly good? Does it promote the good of order? What consequences will it have beyond the field of one's immediate experience? Egoism, however, must suppress such further questions, and in doing so, it becomes incoherent and self-contradictory. The irony of egoism emerges from the fact that commitment to the project of fulfilling one's spontaneous desires demands that at least one desire, the desire to know, must be denied.

Considered in its social ramifications, egoism leaves the individual short-sighted. One's refusal to transcend immediately felt needs and desires frustrates the social process that would educate one in the meaning and values embodied in one's culture. Among the values that one fails to grasp is the good of order, and when one's desires contradict that order, one may become a criminal. Lonergan points to crime as the most obvious manifestation of the interference individual bias effects in human development. The laws societies forge and the institutions they erect to enforce legal sanctions witness to the high statistical probability that governs this failure of the individual to develop.

Group Bias and the Shorter Cycle of Decline. Lonergan speaks of spontaneous intersubjectivity to indicate the form of psychic extroversion operative when men and women instinctively turn to others for acceptance and identity. If the egoism toward which individual bias inclines us proves incoherent by suppressing the desire to know, egoism also places the individual in some contradiction with one's own spontaneous intersubjectivity. The latter tendency can, however, resolve this tension by generating what Lonergan terms "group bias."

As we have seen, spontaneous intersubjectivity generates the ties of blood that bind together the primitive groupings of family and clan. Then, when differentiated common sense arrives at a division of labor in which specialized groups perform distinct tasks, the basis of social order shifts. Practical intelligence replaces spontaneous intersubjectivity as the principle of social organization. That transition

cannot, however, occur without a corresponding adaptation of spontaneous intersubjectivity. People do not soberly reason their way to commitment to the good of order. They require dynamic images that arouse enthusiasm and loyalty. Only affects such as these can effectively bind individuals to their functional groups and unite the groups within a harmoniously operating whole.

Successful adaptation of this sort cuts in two directions. It is a necessary condition for coordinating the distinct functional groups required for the good of order. When, however, the good of order requires change, when new insights would set the wheel of progress in motion on a large scale, the same adaptation becomes counterproductive. Some functional groups may become obsolete, so that progress comes to require social reorganization. Under those circumstances, the existing psychic adaptation becomes an inertial obstacle.

Furthermore, the tendency that gives rise to egoism operates also within the psychically integrated functional groups. Each group has particular needs and interests, and these present themselves with greater immediacy and vividness than can the good of order into which they must be integrated evoke. Once again, psychic spontaneity promotes an undeveloped, experiential criterion of reality and value.

To the extent that this criterion finds uncritical acceptance, it disrupts the harmonious collaboration that ensures the good of order. Each group has its own vested interests, and the need to protect them becomes defensive. Suspicion infiltrates the lines of communication within the social body. Aggressive competition creates a general struggle for material goods and political power. A society structured by the intelligent distribution of necessary functions gives way to a stratified class system, defined by the degree of material well-being and control of political power the respective classes enjoy.

In this situation, group bias distorts progress on the level of civilization. The vested interests of the wealthy and powerful set in place a screen through which new, creative proposals must pass before they can be implemented. Only those ideas which reinforce, or at best,

fail to threaten, the dominant power structure are put into practice. Other, equally valuable insights are suppressed. Because group bias sets the particular interests of a few in place of the common good as the norm for action, development proceeds on an erratic, imbalanced, restricted course.

By distorting the course of social development, group bias engenders a shorter cycle of decline. If one class dominates, others are deprived of wealth and power, and group bias heightens the resultant tension by investing it with affect. Injustice becomes a rallying point for the oppressed. Meanwhile, the imbalanced development fostered by the dominant group heads toward a breakdown of the good of order. At any point in the process, but more likely as its end approaches, oppressed groups may mobilize to seize power. How this comes about depends on the makeup of the conflicting groups.⁹⁹ A reactionary dominant group invites revolution, while a more progressive group tends to integrate its opposition in a liberal movement. In either case, the shift of power from one group to the other provides an unstable solution. The new dominant group will have its own vested interests, these will again set up a screen, and others will suffer the deficiencies of the resultant social policy. Group bias, having divided society, sends it spinning through a relatively short cycle in which power alternates from one group to another.

General Bias and the Longer Cycle of Decline. The criminality in which the egoism to which individual bias leads sets up pockets of resistance on which progress may snag. Group bias penetrates more deeply; it can reduce progress to mindless material expansion. General bias completes this trend when it invades the cultural superstructure of society to pervert the worlds of theory and interiority.¹⁰⁰

The origin of general bias lies in the character of common sense. Common sense, as Lonergan construes the term, is a development of competence in dealing with the practical problems of living, a specialization of intelligence in the practical and concrete. Access to

99. Lonergan, *Insight*, 250.

100. *Ibid.*, 250–63.

the worlds of theory and interiority, however, requires a differentiation of consciousness beyond common sense, and to those lacking such further differentiations, those worlds appear unreal and irrelevant. Furthermore, modern writers have amply documented the phenomenon of *ressentiment*, a perverse tendency to denigrate any excellence that challenges one's own lack of development.¹⁰¹ Encouraged by the very real successes they achieve, people of common sense tend to claim omnicompetence, invoking a crude realism that erects practicality as its supreme norm.

Practical-minded people pride themselves on dealing soberly with the facts of a situation. There is, however, one fact they overlook. Not all so-called facts are fully intelligible. Some of them objectivize infidelity to the exigencies of self-transcendence. Situations that result from such infidelity contain an objectively irrational or surd element. Their apparent intelligibility is merely specious. For common sense, however, considerations such as these are abstract, impractical, and meaningless. General bias allows the so-called facts that objectivize egoism and group bias to determine the further course of history, rendering the possibilities for authentic development ever narrower.

Under the influence of general bias, praxis corrupted by egoism and group bias receives support in the form of pseudo-theory. Lonergan adduces Machiavelli as an example.¹⁰² The cynical abuse of political power has been a constant in recorded history, but it was Machiavelli's achievement to systematize that abuse, promoting it to the status of normative theory. His theory commends itself to common sense because it systematizes the obvious, if specious, intelligibility of concrete situations. Eminently practical, it deals with things as they are. Such pseudo-theory has its own effect. By making the facts of corrupt praxis the determinants of subsequent action, it dignifies the aberration that they concretize with the aura of an ideal, and the probability for further corruption jumps geometrically.

Group bias sets society alternating through a relatively short cycle

101. Lonergan, *Method in Theology*, 273.

102. Lonergan, *The Notion of Fittingness*, 511.

of power shifts, but under the added impact of general bias, society moves into a longer cycle in which culture disintegrates. Where men and women of detached intelligence might lay bare the irrationality of a situation and find creative steps toward the reversal of its dynamic, the weight of general bias ensures the dismissal of their analysis as impractical. Authentic philosophy and religion are rendered impotent. Their representatives can do no more than condemn the literal absurdity of the situation. If they evoke any response at all, it will be resentment. Pseudo-theory carries the day and renders absurdity normative.

Under these circumstances, the human drive toward meaning and value perdures, but the context in which that drive might be actualized has been distorted. The resulting malaise, an experience of alienation,¹⁰³ supplies the dynamic for a final perversion of culture.¹⁰⁴ Meaning and value are still in demand, but the demand is filtered through general bias, and this creates a ready market for myths and ideologies.¹⁰⁵ Alienated men and women still clamor for an ethic, a philosophy, a religion. These, however, must meet the standard of practicality. They must not call the status quo into question. The so-called facts of the situation remain normative, and to keep pace with the expanding surd that those facts concretize, culture moves through a series of decreasingly comprehensive syntheses.

Lonerган sketches a highly simplified schema to trace the course of the longer cycle of general bias.¹⁰⁶ After the instability of medieval culture issued in the Reformation, wars of religion devastated Europe. This horror proved religion incapable of grounding a cultural synthesis; reason suggested itself in its stead. Yet, the advocates of reason differed among themselves, and so, tolerance amidst a plurality of conflicting views emerged as an ideal. People of tolerance cultivate their own gardens, benevolently allowing others to do the same. Such

103. Lonergan, *Method in Theology*, 55.

104. "For among the evils that afflict man, none is graver than the erroneous beliefs which at once distort his mind and make systematic the aberrations of his conduct." Lonergan, *Insight*, 708.

105. "[T]he basic form of ideology is the self-justification of alienated man." Lonergan, *Method in Theology*, 357.

106. Lonergan, *Insight*, 256–57.

benevolence, however, amounts to an abdication of responsibility. A vacuum is created. Bereft of intelligent guidance, society faces the specter of chaos. Because other contenders have abandoned the field, proponents of totalitarian power find a ready welcome for their promise of order.

The Reign of Sin. St. Thomas pointed out that since human development starts from pure potency, the passions will be sure to have their effect. Lonergan notes the ambiguity of the human psyche. Absolutely necessary as the mediator of biological necessity to consciousness, the psyche exhibits a spontaneous extroversion that promotes as real and good whatever is immediately felt as such. By thus tending to bind men and women to the world of immediacy, the psyche generates three biases, and because of the priority of living over learning, of action over reflection, the biases are sure to introduce blind spots into the process of human development. Their psychic force engenders resistance to the exigencies of intellectual, moral, and religious self-transcendence.

Individual and group bias militate directly against civilizational progress. They set in motion a relatively shorter cycle, in which oppressed groups succeed to the dominant position of the favored class, only to repeat and intensify the inadequacy of their predecessors. Each turn of the cycle responds to a situation brought about by corporate egoism and the suppression of creative insights. Thus, each turn brings more of the same, and the surd element introduced by individual and group bias expands.

As conditions degenerate, they become progressively opaque to the attempts of human intelligence to master them. Instead, because of its evident results, technological advance takes the lead, liberated by the particular interests it promotes from social and economic policies that would subordinate technological advance to the good of order. Civilizational progress shrinks to the level to the level of the purely material.

General bias completes the picture. It renders the proposals of authentic, detached intelligence irrelevant. Men and women assuage

their need for meaning and value by grasping for the myths and ideologies that reinforce corrupt praxis with pseudo-theory. Belief systems begin functioning to justify the irrational situation brought about by resistance to the exigencies of self-transcendence, and those beliefs pervert the worlds of theory and interiority. Once the surd element penetrates and pervades the cultural dimension of society, men and women are left morally impotent.¹⁰⁷ The history they forge becomes, not a response to the divine gift inscribed in the order of creation, but a reign of sin.

Third Approximation: A Heuristic of Redemption

Lonerган completes his theological analysis of history by raising a third question: “How can the reign of sin be destroyed and the human race brought back to living in conformity with reason?”¹⁰⁸ In response to this question, he works out a heuristic of redemption in the final chapter of *Insight*, while his notes *On The Notion of Fittingness* offer a selective abbreviation of that material. In *Method*, he recasts the major elements of the heuristic.

As was the case with his analysis of sin,¹⁰⁹ Lonergan’s dissertation on St. Thomas provides the point of departure for his approach to redemption. “With the human problem so clearly conceived,” he writes, “St. Thomas has at once its solution, a greater actuation of human potency.”¹¹⁰ St. Thomas went on to specify the character of this greater actuation as he refined his doctrine of grace and the virtues. Rather than repeat St. Thomas, however, Lonergan sets about transposing Aquinas’s insight into the contemporary context. In *On the Notion of Fittingness*, he proceeds directly to a consideration of the theological virtues of faith, hope, and charity, but in *Insight*, he prefaces this consideration with a series of “more metaphysical, cosmic aspects” of his heuristic.¹¹¹

107. On moral impotence, see Lonergan, *Insight*, 650–53.

108. Lonergan, *The Notion of Fittingness*, 507.

109. See *supra*, 333.

110. Lonergan, *Grace and Freedom*, 42.

111. Lonergan, *Insight*, 718–20, at 720.

To this end, the worldview that Lonergan finds grounded in the recognition by the empirical natural sciences of two distinct kinds of law comes into play. Classical laws govern the ideal occurrence of physical, chemical, and biological events, and while these laws enjoy universality and a kind of necessity, they are also abstract. They only hold good with the proviso, “other things being equal.” To complement this abstractness, science also invokes the statistical laws that express the probabilities for the actual occurrence of a particular type of event. Combined, these laws suggest a worldview that regards the universe as a process in which the possibilities contained in an original, basic situation are being realized according to a discernible order. Events fall into schemes of recurrence, and the occurrence and survival of any particular scheme depends upon the previous functioning of other schemes. Furthermore, the various schemes emerge in order of complexity, with the more intricate schemes arising later and in dependence on less intricate schemes. The emergence of life, for instance, presupposes the functioning of a number of complex chemical schemes.

The initial basic situation renders all the schemes possible, but the probability of the occurrence of any given scheme depends on the emergence of the previous simpler schemes that condition it. When an antecedent scheme moves from probability to actuality, the probability of a later, dependent, more complex scheme jumps in a geometric progression.

It is this worldview of emergent probability that governs the “metaphysical and cosmic aspects” of Lonergan’s heuristic of redemption. Human beings, and with them, the problem of evil, have come into being within a universe ordered by emergent probability. The imagination tends to picture God and his dealing with creation in temporal categories. Thus, God first creates, but because human beings then sin, God responds by offering redemption. It follows that redemption takes on the character of a divine afterthought, God’s improvised solution to the disruption of God’s plan. To avoid this

anthropomorphism, Lonergan postulates redemption as a harmonious continuation of the single actual order of the universe willed by God.

Within that order, the problem of moral evil and sin arises from the incomplete, open structure of humanity and the subjection of human development to the psychically grounded distorting factors that Lonergan terms biases. To meet this aspect of the problem, the solution will include some compensating perfection of human beings. Lonergan writes of new “conjugate forms” in human beings to characterize this perfection. The phrase corresponds to the metaphysical category of accident, and Lonergan employs it to make a negative point. The solution to the problem will involve an accidental, not a substantial change in human beings. No new super-species will come into existence; such a new creature would abrogate, not resolve, the problem of evil.

Because the problem arises because living has priority over learning and being persuaded to the good, the conjugate forms in question will take the shape of habits that serve to reverse this priority. These habits will perform a precise function. Because the biases draw their strength from the spontaneous extroversion of the psyche, the habits in question will provide a higher synthesis of human activity that will integrate the power of the psyche with the human drive to self-transcendence.

Lonergan also postulates that the solution, while remaining a harmonious continuation of the actual order of the universe, will also be “in some sense transcendent or supernatural.” The root of the problem is permanent and universal. Philosophic attempts to understand the problem face a singularly arduous task, and even should they escape the distorting effect of the biases, they can hardly expect widespread comprehension, much less acceptance. Neither is sincere goodwill likely to provide a solution, because such goodwill readily commits itself to the errors that reinforce the reign of sin. Hence, Lonergan insists rigorously that only with the affirmation of God’s existence does the manifest fact of evil become a problem in the technical sense, that is, a difficulty to which one may reasonably seek a

solution. He writes: “[E]vil is, not a mere fact, but a problem, only if one attempts to reconcile it with the goodness of God, and, if God is good, then there is not only a problem of evil, but also a solution.”¹¹²

In some sense transcendent, the solution will involve habits that do not result simply from an accumulation of insights. As agents of a higher synthesis of the systems that constitute the structure of human beings, they will not violate the integrity of that structure. Hence, human beings will not receive these habits without an exercise of rational apprehension and free choice. Thus far, then, the solution involves something as yet unspecified which, when apprehended and consented to, will generate habits that effect a higher integration of human activity. That higher integration will reverse the priority of living over learning and being persuaded to the good. It will overcome the distorting influence of the spontaneous extroversion of the psyche and integrate the psyche with the exigencies of self-transcendence. As thus perfecting nature, the solution will respect both the general law of emergent probability and the autonomy of human rationality.

In *On the Notion of Fittingness*, Lonergan specifies the new conjugate forms with the traditional triad of faith, hope, and charity, but in *Insight*, he reverses that order to deal with charity first. Subsequent developments in Lonergan’s thought confer significance on this reversal.

Charity. Lonergan introduces the virtue of charity by contrasting it with justice.¹¹³ The problem of evil manifests itself in situations shot through with irrationality in which individuals are abused, groups oppressed, and whole nations exploited. All of these situations bear witness to the workings of individual, group, and general bias. Justice would aim to redress the inequities in which the problem of evil manifests itself by restoring to the individual, group, or nation its due. The social surd, however, that generates inequity arises from the disorder of human subjectivity. Hence, justice, failing to penetrate deeply enough, proves an inadequate solution. While justice may

112. Lonergan, *Insight*, 716.

113. Lonergan, *On the Notion of Fittingness*, 514–16.

restore equity, justice cannot eradicate the self-interest and ensuing hostility that generate and find reinforcement in unjust situations. A restoration of the balance of justice would achieve only a fragile and ephemeral solution, a brief moment of pause interrupting the cycles through which power alternates while reason declines.

Charity short-circuits the cycle of evil. In charity, one recognizes and affirms the inviolable ontic value of persons, including those who do one wrong. Instead of resorting to violence as the practical response to injustice, one takes on oneself the violence that comes with affirming value in an irrational social situation. Allowing the dynamic of irrationality to spend itself on one's own person, one transforms the objectivization of evil, the suffering inflicted on one, into an affirmation of value. Returning good for evil, one reverses the dynamic of irrationality.

Charity, then, or self-sacrificing love, corresponds to the problem of evil as an element in its solution. In *Insight*, Lonergan develops the significance of this love by ruminating on the notion of good will.¹¹⁴ Using the language of scholasticism, he recalls the axiom that the will is good to the extent that it follows intellect. Intellect, however, is animated by an unrestricted desire to know everything about everything, and thus, it heads toward God, the unrestricted act of understanding. Hence, the will becomes good to the extent that it matches this drive of intellect and wills God. Because God is person, good will consists ultimately in loving God. Furthermore, in loving God, one wills the actual order of the universe that God has chosen, and this order defines the good for all persons. Willing that order, then, involves willing the good for all persons, that is, loving them. In addition, emergent probability governs the actual order of the universe chosen by God, and in a world of emergent probability, not all schemes of recurrence survive. Some fall victim to decline and become dead ends. On the human level, decline expresses itself in the social surd, so that willing the actual order of the universe entails both acknowledging the social surd and embracing its solution. Good will

114. Lonergan, *Insight*, 720–22.

thus raises the surd to a potential good by transforming it in self-sacrificing love.

Finally, Lonergan qualifies self-sacrificing love with two notes. No one achieves self-transcendence in an uninterrupted line of advancing development. Everyone has, in some way, contributed to decline. For this reason, self-sacrificing love is always repentant. On the contrary, as the agent of the forward dynamism of the universe, love is joyful.

Hope. Self-sacrificing love cannot but appear supremely impractical in a context ruled by the general bias of common sense, for which self-preservation becomes the ultimate norm for prudent action. Self-sacrificing love negates the pseudo-logic of the existing irrational situation, and thus, rejects the norm of practicality. Lonergan assigns to hope the function of supporting the willingness of self-sacrificing love to meet evil with good.¹¹⁵ If, for Lonergan, the final goal of the human desire to know is God, hope serves to render that spontaneous and unrestricted desire of intellect a consciously chosen, habitual orientation. Hope instills the confidence that one's unrestricted desire will reach its goal, and because that goal transcends the capacity of human intellect, hope finally becomes confidence that God will act to communicate Godself to men and women.

Faith. A habitual stance of self-sacrificing love, supported by hope, implies another, more directly noetic aspect to the solution. Good will come into stable self-possession when it can thematize the term of its basic dynamism. The same holds for hope, which finds security in knowledge of the one in whom it trusts. Hence, Lonergan postulates that the reversal of the social surd through charity and hope requires also the possession of "certain essential truths."¹¹⁶ Knowledge that God exists and that God is providing a solution to the problem of evil constitutes the primary element in this noetic dimension.¹¹⁷ Such knowledge about God implies truths about human beings as well, and Lonergan specifies these as an affirmation of our spiritual nature, freedom, responsibility, and actual sinfulness.¹¹⁸

115. Lonergan, *Insight*, 723–24.

116. Lonergan, *On the Notion of Fittingness*, 515.

117. Lonergan, *Insight*, 724.

The necessity of this noetic dimension brings Lonergan's heuristic up against a paradox. The expanding social surd renders the very notion of truth problematic. The various forms of bias would restrict the exercise of intelligence to what lies immediately at hand. Degenerate praxis seizes on myths and ideologies to justify itself, and these receive a specious verification from the irrational situation to which they correspond. The circle appears vicious and complete. Furthermore, even if isolated individuals managed to arrive at the essential truths of God and human beings, their success would not meet the problem of evil. Even as the problem is universal and permanent, so also must the solution be permanent and universally accessible.

A difficulty of the same sort arises and finds solution on a more general plane. No generation starts off from a state of primitive ignorance. Each receives from its predecessor a heritage of civilization and culture, so that an active process of tradition provides the continuity that permits further advance. The key to that process lies in belief.

The truth that any individual attains through independent, personal discovery forms but a single strand within a complex pattern of knowledge that one possesses chiefly through belief, and this holds true, not only in the realm of common sense, but also in the empirical natural sciences. Belief provides access to the ongoing world mediated by meaning, and because this world need not be constructed anew with each individual or generation, progress is possible. This general function of belief suggests its role in resolving the paradox generated by the noetic dimension of Lonergan's heuristic. Belief provides the appropriate means by which the essential truths about God and humanity can be rendered universally and permanently accessible.

The function of belief indicates also the social character of the solution to the problem of evil. Human intelligence develops within the context of collaboration, either the broad collaboration of a given culture or the more differentiated collaboration of specialized communities within a culture. The solution to the problem of evil will

likewise involve a collaboration, to which individuals gain access by belief.

This collaboration will not be simply that of men and women with one another. Because the solution must be, in some sense, transcendent, the community of believers will constitute a human collaboration with God in overcoming the problem of evil. Their belief will take on a transcendent note, finding its motive in the truthfulness of the God who originates the collaboration. Hence, Lonergan can speak of the belief through which the noetic dimension is realized as an act of faith in a divine revelation.¹¹⁹

While its members enter the collaboration through belief, they are not reduced to passivity. They will take up the tasks of making the solution known, of transmitting it from one generation to another, and of relating it to particular situations. Furthermore, entrance into the faith community and assumption of its tasks does not exempt one from the human condition. Precisely as human, the collaboration will remain subject to the aberrations to which men and women are prone, and so, the collaboration will take normal human measures to guard against aberration. Lonergan finds it appropriate that the faith community organize itself in an institutional manner, with authoritative structures capable of making binding decisions regarding truth and error.

Finally, the collaboration is not merely human. It is also, in some manner, transcendent, bearing the divine solution to the problem of evil. It originates with God. This origin grounds a confidence that despite all its possibilities for error, the faith community will not fall wholly prey to the reign of sin.

Mystery. For all his intellectualism, Lonergan is no rationalist. When he analyzes the “conjugate forms” in *Insight*, he links charity and hope with the will and faith with the intellect. He does not, however, fail to take into account the experiential matrix from which all human understanding, judgment, and decision arise. Cognitive and moral activity occurs within a flow of consciousness, and self-transcendence

119. Lonergan, *On the Notion of Fittingness*, 515.

begins when one raises one's experience to the intelligent level of understanding through acts of insight into images selected from that flow.

Not all the elements of experience contained in the flow of consciousness receive such attention. There operates a selective factor, interest, which decides the effective shape of one's experience. The psyche plays a role on developing that selective factor, and, as we have seen, Lonergan has taken the psychic conditioning of the shape of experience as the starting point for his account of sin. The psyche manifests a spontaneous extroversion that engenders biases, and the latter distort human development, both individual and societal.

The stability of the higher synthesis introduced with charity, hope, and faith requires a corresponding transformation of the flow of consciousness. Lonergan develops the category of mystery to explicate the aspect of the solution to the problem of evil related to the sensitive, psychically conditioned substratum of human intentionality. He has postulated a noetic dimension to the solution that would function to render charity and hope secure. The faith community will possess the essential truths about God and humanity, finding in God's truthfulness, the motive for believing them. In that sense, the members of the collaboration will accept the essential truths as a revelation. Concretely, that revelation will take the form of mystery.

Lonergan uses the term "mystery" to designate an affect-laden image that exercises a triple function.¹²⁰ First, the image symbolizes the constitutive orientation of human intentionality to a transcendent term that lies beyond all finite knowing, to God. Second, the image acts as a sign; it involves an interpretive element from which the essential truths about God and humanity can be apprehended. Finally, the image as sensible evokes affect. The affect serves to integrate the dynamic flow of consciousness with the basic intentionality toward God, and more specifically, with the deeds of hope and self-sacrificing love rendered necessary by the fact of evil. Such an image or pattern of images may be called mystery for two reasons. It effectively symbolizes

120. Lonergan, *Insight*, 744–45.

humanity's orientation to the mystery of God. Furthermore, the faith community that receives this pattern of images as revelation will attribute its origin to the mystery of divine wisdom.

Further developments. The categories with which Lonergan articulates his heuristic of redemption in *Insight* derive from a faculty psychology based in a metaphysical anthropology. Thus, the key elements of the heuristic correspond to the faculties of intellect (faith), will (charity and hope), and to sensitivity (mystery). Yet, Lonergan's performance in articulating the heuristic differs from a metaphysical anthropology in two respects. Rather than beginning with objects and working back to acts, habits, and faculties, he begins from the data of consciousness to engage in the analysis of human intentionality that yields his generalized empirical method. In addition, he sets the anthropology thus derived within the context of world process as emergent probability in place of a medieval worldview that orders static essences hierarchically. In his later writings, the distance from the traditional metaphysical approach widens further and a shift occurs in the configuration of the elements of the heuristic. In his 1968 Aquinas lecture at Marquette University, Lonergan drops even the categories of faculty psychology to render explicit the analysis of conscious intentionality in which he had been engaged,¹²¹ and in *Method*, he utilizes that analysis as the basis for an account of religion.¹²²

Consciousness, in Lonergan's analysis, involves both the activities by which one intends objects and the self-presence of the subject of those activities, and he notes that the quality of one's self-presence intensifies as one proceeds through the series of intentional activities that constitute cognitional self-transcendence—sheer experience of the data of sense, inquiry and understanding, reflection and judgment—and on to the plane of what he terms real self-transcendence or discernment of intentional feelings, judgment of value, decision and action. He locates the genesis of religion in a transformation, a conversion, of the immediate self-presence that

121. Lonergan, "The Subject," *A Second Collection*, 69–86.

122. Lonergan, *Method in Theology*, 101–24.

accompanies the intentional activities by which one deals with value and that issue in real, as distinct from simply cognitional, self-transcendence.

As analogues to this transformation, Lonergan points to the experience of falling in love, of dedicating oneself lovingly to spouse and children, to one's nation or to one's fellow human beings. Such particular loves reorient one and provide the focal point in relation to which the value of the courses of action open to one is discerned. They become the first principle, as it were, of one's conscious living.

Besides these particular loves, it is also possible to fall in love in an unrestricted manner as one finds oneself increasingly open to value in all its manifestations. This state constitutes the ultimate actuation of conscious intentionality. Such a state of being in love unrestrictedly is directed toward God as the transcendent ground of value, though that orientation may remain implicit. As a conscious state of one's immediate self-presence, it is experienced, but not yet known. One may be in love and act out of that love quite spontaneously and unreflectively. Lonergan cites Paul Tillich's phrase, "being grasped by ultimate concern," to express this possibility.

Even though this state of being in love in an unrestricted fashion may not have moved to reflective self-possession, it already exercises a cognitive function. As an apprehension of transcendent value, operative though not thematized, it casts a light in which all other values are apprehended in their relation to transcendent value, a light in which vital values, the good of order, esthetic values, and the ontic value of persons all find their proper place. In *Method*, Lonergan describes this cognitive function of religious loving as "the eyes of love" and employs the term "faith" to designate it. In the context of this usage, he now reserves the term "faith" to articulate what the earlier tradition spoke of as the *lumen fidei*.

Thus far, Lonergan has constructed the category, religious conversion, as a transformation of one's immediate self-consciousness that occurs when one falls in love in an unrestricted fashion. As experienced, this transformation may be sudden and dramatic, or it

may be a gradual process. "Conversion may be compacted into the moment of a blinded Saul falling from his horse on the way to Damascus. It may be extended over the slow maturing process of a lifetime. It may satisfy an intermediate measure."¹²³

As an experience in the immediacy of one's self-consciousness, however, religious conversion comes to completion in the world mediated by meaning. Unrestricted loving finds its complement in what Lonergan terms "the word" of religious expression. By its outer word, conversion becomes a social and historical reality. The word of religious expression embraces the full gamut of possible vehicles of meaning and serves to mediate the faith born of unrestricted loving to consciousness. Faith, the eyes of love, enables one to recognize the value of accepting as true the religious beliefs of a community, beliefs that thematize, ratify, and reinforce religious conversion. Religious conversion comes to full self-possession through the word that thematizes the pre-reflective content of faith to express the origin and implications of conversion. It is in religious conversion that Lonergan finds fulfilled the "greater actuation of human potency" that St. Thomas postulated as the solution to the problem of evil.

Closing the Circle

The final three theses of Lonergan's *De Verbo Incarnato* offer his closest approximation to a soteriological tract. In them, he first ascertains how Scripture proclaims the fact of redemption in Christ Jesus. Turning next to the ecclesiastical tradition, he studies the theological category, satisfaction, which came to dominate understanding of the biblical proclamation for a millennium. In a last step, he drives toward the unifying intelligibility of these diverse statements of Scripture and tradition and arrives at the Law of the Cross. The Law of the Cross, Lonergan asserts, expresses the essence or the intrinsic intelligibility of redemption.

The full significance of Lonergan's proposal exceeds the confines

123. Lonergan, "Theology in its New Context," *A Second Collection*, 66.

of the neoscholastic thesis in which it occurs. We have seen how, chafing under the constraints of the manual genre, Lonergan sought to compensate for its inadequacy by introducing lengthy prenotes and scholia into the body of his text and composing substantive supplements to accompany it. By such means, he was attempting to remedy the ahistorical, classicist method of neoscholasticism with a dose of history. This clash of horizons was evident in the unpublished supplement on the redemption, with its concern for the historical causality of Christ, and also in the notes *On the Notion of Fittingness*. In the latter, when he turned to the question of the *convenientia* of the Incarnation, Lonergan brought to bear the theology of history that he had been working on since his student days. In that theological analysis, he discerned, in the unfolding of historical process, the interaction of three vectors: human creativity, sin, and redemption. Of those three, the categories of sin and redemption are specific to the Christian tradition, what Lonergan would later characterize as special theological categories,¹²⁴ and in *Insight*, he secured their meaning by grounding them in his transposition into intentionality analysis of Aquinas's metaphysical account of human intellectual and moral activity. Subsequent to *Insight*, his thought continued to develop in significant ways. Students in Rome opened him to the challenge of the *Geisteswissenschaften*, of hermeneutics and critical history,¹²⁵ prompting him to develop his cognitional theory into a theory of meaning,¹²⁶ and he also came to differentiate more clearly the intentional activities with which one engages value as opening onto a distinct level beyond those of experience, understanding, and judgment.¹²⁷

In all of this, Lonergan was working out his response to the general problem of integration posed to theology by the transition from classicism to a modern, scientific and historically minded culture. If Aquinas and the medieval schoolmen forged their *summae* in response to a systematic-theoretic exigence, Lonergan discerned in the

124. Lonergan, *Method in Theology*, 281–93.

125. Lonergan, "Insight Revisited," *A Second Collection*, 277.

126. Lonergan, *Method in Theology*, 57–99.

127. *Ibid.*, 30–52.

challenge of modernity a further exigence, this time critical and methodic, one that marked the emergence of a new stage of meaning beyond common sense and theory. Modernity presented both dazzling advances and a terrible ambiguity. The proven success of empirical science emboldened a claim that would restrict the real to what fell within the scope of that method, while the discovery of human historicity cast a shadow of relativism and historicism. Along with its advances, modernity produced a culture in crisis in that the very objectivity of meaning and value came into question. To meet this crisis, Lonergan set about differentiating the realm of interiority, the realm of meaning constituted by reflectively appropriating the recurrent and normative pattern of conscious operations through which women and men realize their humanity in a project of self-transcendence. The upshot is his account of transcendental or generalized empirical method.

That account undergirds Lonergan's theological analysis of history. Employed genetically, it yields an understanding of the ideal lines of human progress in achieving the good. Wielded dialectically, it traces the cumulative distortions that constitute a reign of sin. The structure of the latter provides the basis for a heuristic of redemption.

Hence, we can ask: how does the Law of the Cross proposed in Thesis 17 of *De Verbo Incarnato* as the law or essence of redemption meet, as promised in the previous thesis, the general problem of integration? More specifically, how does the Law of the Cross relate to the heuristic of redemption articulated in *Insight*?

The Outer Word, Mystery and the New Testament Witness to Christ. In *Method in Theology*, Lonergan discerns two moments in the constitution of religion. An inner word experienced in the immediacy of one's consciousness evokes surrender and commitment to what is transcendent in loveliness or value. Conscious, but of itself, not known as such, the inner word finds completion and stability in the outer word, whereby that immediate and individual experience is mediated by meaning. With the outer word, the experience of religious

conversion enters the public forum to become the basis of community and tradition.

The outer word of religion exploits the multifarious resources whereby meaning can be expressed and carried. Meaning can be communicated intersubjectively, as by a smile, as well as through art, symbol, and language, and it can be incarnated in persons. Besides this communicative function, meaning also exercises the cognitive function whereby the real is known, an effective function whereby the real is transformed by human decision and action, and a constitutive function whereby the identity of both institutions and individuals comes to be. Through their acts of meaning, men and women gain access in succession to the realms of common sense, theory, and interiority, the latter two emerging as distinct stages from the first.

A key link between the theory of meaning articulated in *Method* and the concept of mystery formulated earlier in *Insight* lies in the notion of symbol. In *Method*, Lonergan defines symbol as “an image of a real or imaginary object that evokes a feeling or is evoked by a feeling.”¹²⁸ Symbols meet the need for internal communication between, on the one hand, intentional consciousness, and, on the other, organism and psyche. Among the feelings they evoke or are evoked by are the intentional response to value, so that “[i]t is through symbols that mind and body, mind and heart, heart and body communicate.”¹²⁹

In *Insight*, Lonergan postulated mystery as a component in his heuristic of redemption, and, we recall, defined mystery as an affect-laden image that would exercise three functions. It would symbolize the orientation of intentional consciousness to its transcendent term, unrestricted intelligibility, truth, and goodness. It would act as sign from which the essential truths about God and humanity could be drawn. Third, it would evoke affect, and in so doing, overcome the spontaneous extroversion of the psyche that generates bias, and so, it would integrate the flow of consciousness with the basic intentionality toward God and with the deeds of hope and self-sacrificing love, of

128. Lonergan, *Method in Theology*, 64.

129. *Ibid.*, 67.

themselves so opposed to that spontaneous extroversion, which alone could meet and transform the fact of evil.

Within the context of this nest of terms and relations, the character of the New Testament witness to Christ, from which Lonergan drew his first soteriological thesis in *De Verbo Incarnato*, becomes clear. The incarnate meaning that constitutes the identity of Jesus stands at the origin of the Christian community. That meaning serves as the outer word that evokes, expresses, and specifies religious conversion as Christian. Access to that meaning requires the mediation of a process of tradition, and that process has its beginning in the acts of meaning, that is, the acts of experience, understanding, judgment, and decision, of those contemporaneous with Jesus' words, deeds, and destiny. At an early stage, the meaning perceived in Jesus by Christian faith was committed to writing. Those documents eventually canonized as the books of the New Testament present a linguistic expression of the meaning of Jesus, which subsequent Christian tradition has accepted as adequate, and in some sense, normative. The New Testament offers a privileged expression of the meaning that the Christian community believes was incarnate in Jesus.

That meaning is presented as Gospel, or good news, the acceptance of which entails a *metanoia* on the part of its hearers. In terms of Lonergan's analysis of religion, the interest of early Christian witness to Jesus lay in religious conversion. Christian proclamation put forward conversion, thematized as becoming followers of Christ, as the fulfillment of human destiny. Under the concrete conditions of human existence, this fulfillment was also presented as redemptive, that is, as the solution to the problem of evil.

For the task of linguistically articulating the meaning incarnate in Jesus, the imagination provided a principal instrument. Endeavoring to express and communicate Jesus' identity and significance in all its forcefulness, those who contributed to the formative tradition of the New Testament constructed dramatic narratives that culminated in his fate and destiny. Guided by their interest in conversion and redemption, they enriched and reshaped their memories of Jesus'

words and deeds with appropriate images drawn from the Hellenistic world, and above all, from the Old Testament. Thus, for example, they identified the one who died on the cross as the prophet who was to come, the Messiah, the Suffering Servant, the Lord, Son of God. Each image placed at the service of Christian faith a wealth of symbolic power, evoking the meaning incarnate in Jesus.

As symbolic discourse, the New Testament witness to Christ fulfills the functions with which Lonergan defines the category of mystery. That witness presents a patterned set of images that symbolize the transcendent realm toward which human self-transcendence is oriented, that articulate the meaning of what they symbolize, and that act with psychic force to integrate sensitivity and affectivity with the dynamic of self-transcendence.

Thus, the New Testament witness to Christ symbolizes the ultimate realm of mystery that the transcendental notion of being and value anticipate and toward which they drive. The converted subject, when she hears the New Testament proclaimed in liturgical celebration, or when she devotes herself to private meditation on it, receives its proclamation as God's word. This word thematizes her religious conversion, the unrestricted love that she has received and accepted as the integrating center of her life. From the New Testament, she learns to identify the ultimate source and term of that love as the Father of Jesus Christ, the Yahweh of Israel who has sent his son among human beings. In light of that gift of love, she recognizes Jesus as the revelation of the Father who is completing his mission by sending the Spirit. The Christian Scriptures symbolize the realm of the transcendent in Trinitarian imagery that interprets that realm in interpersonal terms.

The central, controlling image of the New Testament witness is that of the risen Christ who had been crucified. Scripture places that image in a dramatic context. Jesus' death and destiny fulfill God's plan for creation. The opposition of Pharisees, priests, and Romans casts his death as the fate of the innocent one. Jesus persists in challenging his opponents with an unconditional affirmation of value and answers

their evil with a love rooted in that of the Father. This leads to the cross, but with the image of the resurrection, the New Testament affirms that such a life is not futile. God vindicated it. The New Testament proclaims in a variety of ways that in accepting death as the culmination of the resistance of evil to his words and deeds, Jesus went on to further life. He became a source of life for those who would accept his words and perform similar deeds. Inviting men and women to follow Jesus through death to new life, the New Testament presents him as the model of the process of redemption.

The New Testament witness symbolizes the realm of the transcendent mystery by presenting Jesus as God's self-revelation. It thematizes the significance of the central image of Jesus crucified and risen as redemptive. Finally, through the symbolic character of its imagery, that witness acquires and exercises psychic force. One's spontaneous intersubjectivity comes into play when the New Testament presents the ultimate transcendent as a person who enters into intimate relations with men and women by sending his son among them and communicating his son's spirit to them. The concreteness of the image of a human being whose words, deeds, and destiny embody and reveal both the character of God and the destiny of humankind evokes affect which integrates human psyche and sensitivity with the drive to moral and religious self-transcendence. This investment with psychic force through symbolic imagery renders the New Testament witness capable of achieving its common sense goal of inviting, convincing, and persuading and, by effecting affective integration of this sort, fulfills the perduring function that Lonergan assigns to mystery. Mystery generates religion; the Christian mystery communicated in the New Testament witness generates Christianity.

Lonergan's heuristic also postulates the traditional triad of charity, hope, and faith as the response to mystery. These are integral to the response of the religiously converted subject to the mystery of Jesus presented in the New Testament. The authenticity of the subject's response to Jesus' injunction to love God above all else finds its measure in the deeds by which one follows Jesus in self-sacrificing love

for one's neighbor. While the wisdom of the world finds such deeds of self-sacrifice foolishness, the converted subject finds, in union with the risen Christ, the strength to resist that wisdom, the firm hope that one's self-sacrifice will not prove futile. Faith in the reality of God revealed in Jesus and conviction of one's own status as redeemed sinner underpin the dynamism of charity and hope.

In *Method in Theology*, Lonergan refines this analysis when he distinguishes faith from beliefs.¹³⁰ If the New Testament witness to Christ constitutes a mystery as the term is used in Lonergan's heuristic of redemption, that mystery articulates in a symbolic mode, the shared beliefs that constitute the Christian community. Faith, now understood as the light generated by the gift of unrestricted love, opens the horizon within which the value of accepting those beliefs becomes manifest. That value lies in their truth as expressions of the meaning of the gift of God's love in Christ Jesus.

The New Testament witness to Christ, we are suggesting, and with it, the first of Lonergan's soteriological theses in *De Verbo Incarnato*, belongs to the stage of common sense discourse. The imagination took a leading role in the effort to linguistically unpack the meaning incarnate in Jesus and to convince others of that meaning, drawing chiefly in that effort on the power of symbol. The creative dynamism of the newly emergent Christian imagination, which bore its first fruits in the New Testament, moved forward as the writers of the patristic era further explored the potentialities for expression offered by the world of common sense.

At the same time, the conditions for a move into a second stage of meaning began to coalesce. On the one hand, the Christian community deepened its engagement with the resources offered by the thought and culture of the Greco-Roman heritage of the empire. At the same time, the abundant diversity of images in the New Testament provoked questions. The relation of Jesus to the Father demanded clarification. To this end, the Fathers at Nicaea found it necessary to forge a technical, non-biblical term controlling the meaning of the biblical

130. Lonergan, *Method in Theology*, 115–24.

symbols. Subsequent councils found themselves transforming this regrettable exception into a rule. At the source of this ferment, the limits of common sense expression were making themselves felt, giving rise to a systematic-theoretic exigence as the need to render a coherent account of the cognitive dimension of biblical symbol came to the fore.

Besides signaling the emergence of the systematic-theoretic exigence, Lonergan discerns a further dimension to the significance of Nicaea. He remarks in *Method* that religious conversion heads toward its intellectual counterpart,¹³¹ and in the development toward Nicaea, he finds a process of trial and error through which that dynamism of religious conversion reached its term.¹³²

The issue of intellectual conversion focuses on how one identifies the real. Lonergan discerns three perennial stances, materialism, idealism, and critical realism, and he relates them dialectically through his account of cognitional praxis. If human knowing consists in a compound of experience, understanding, and judgment, then the real is identified as the object of reasonable affirmation. Human beings begin, however, as infants in a world of immediate experience, a world in which the real is what confronts one through the senses. Materialists absolutize this infantile criterion to identify the real with the sensibly experienced. Like materialists, idealists note the difference between experience and understanding. In a pre-critical stage, they may identify the real with the purely intelligible, relegating the world of experience to a shadowy form of inferior existence. In a post-critical stage, however, they may emphasize the correlation between intelligibility and the human activity from which it proceeds. If they then accept the materialist criterion of reality, they leave human beings trapped in an illusory world constituted by the projections of one's own subjectivity.

For Lonergan, the outer word that expresses the meanings and values constitutive of Christian community implies a realism, not the

131. Lonergan, *Method in Theology*, 243.

132. Lonergan, *The Way to Nicaea: The Dialectical Development of Trinitarian Thought* (London: Darton, Longman, and Todd, 1976).

naïve sort that identifies human knowing in mythic terms as some sort of a look, directed at either the sensible or the intelligible, but the critical sort that locates the attainment of truth in the act of judging. In Lonergan's reading, the controversies leading to the acceptance of Nicaea, in fact, though only implicitly, turned about this point. It was no lack of faith, but rather, his Stoic materialist presuppositions that prevented Tertullian from achieving an adequate articulation of the divinity of Christ. Origen operated from the idealist assumptions of Middle Platonism with no greater success. When, however, Athanasius interpreted Nicaea's *homousion* as simply a rule governing propositions about the relation of Son and Father, he implicitly appealed to the norm of critical realism. Nicaea offered no imaginable account of the Son's relation of difference-in-identity with the Father, nor did it claim any intellectual intuition that would penetrate that relation. Rather, the Fathers at Nicaea contented themselves with affirming the reality of that relation as a mystery of faith proposed by Scripture and Christian practice.

The ferment of the patristic era gave rise to a systematic-theoretic exigence, and this found fulfillment in the Middle Ages with the differentiation of theology from its matrix in the imaginative, symbol-making activity of common sense religious practice and expression. That exigence imposed the task of assimilating the entire Christian tradition within a coherent whole. A rush of scholarly activity provided the materials for meeting that task. Collections of patristic writing assembled the data. Voluminous commentaries pushed for understanding. A work like Abelard's *Sic et Non* exposed diverging interpretations. Key terms received technically precise definitions. Contact with Islamic culture brought with it the rediscovery of Aristotle. The stage was set for a genius such as Aquinas, who set about offering an account of "everything that pertains to the Christian religion" according to the *ordo disciplinae*.¹³³ Into that account, we have seen, Aquinas integrated the novelty introduced by Anselm. Lonergan's second soteriological thesis recapitulates this development,

133. Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae*, Prologue.

and thus, corresponds to the second stage of meaning, that of systematic theory.

The grandeur of the medieval achievement remains beyond question, and yet, it demands to be superseded for several reasons. First, the worldview assumed by medieval theology rested upon a blend of biblical narrative with Greek cosmology, and modern science has progressively dismantled that worldview. Galileo hastened the displacement of a geocentric universe in favor of a heliocentric system, and the latter has itself fallen victim to astrophysicists' vision of the solar system as but a small unit within a far larger galaxy, which itself is but a minute part of a vast cosmic array, the whole still in process of expanding from an initial Big Bang. Pascal could well mutter that "the eternal silence of these vast spaces fills me with dread."

Second, the same blend of biblical narrative with Greek philosophy underlay a serene confidence in humankind's unique and secure place at the apex of creation and its lordship over all other creatures. At present, however, evolutionary biology, interventionary techniques made possible by discoveries in embryology, and the ongoing development of artificial intelligence conspire with contemporary cosmology to make some call this assumption into question.

Third, the emergence of the empirical method of modern science colluded with a development in Western philosophy running through Descartes, Hume, Kant, Hegel, and Nietzsche that comprised a "turn to the subject." Kant, whose philosophy can be read as a formalization of Newton's classical physics, pronounced the end of metaphysics, while Nietzsche glimpsed the nihilism following upon the death of Hegel's God.

Finally, medieval theologians drew upon the patristic heritage to devise sophisticated techniques of biblical hermeneutics. They did so, however, within the security of what Paul Ricoeur has dubbed a "primitive naïveté," the unproblematic, taken-for-granted character that its sociological function as the foundational myth of the medieval world won for the biblical narrative.¹³⁴ That first naïveté shattered,

134. P. Ricoeur, *The Symbolism of Evil*, trans. Emerson Buchanan (Boston: Beacon, 1969), 351.

however, with the emergence of historical consciousness. By the nineteenth century, the discipline of critical history had established itself, and with it, the facticity of many aspects of the biblical narrative has come into question. H. S. Reimarus, for example, raised the question of “the historical Jesus,” and the research engendered by that question continues at present in a third phase.

In all of this, modernity seemed to some among both its proponents and traditional Christians to have launched a full-scale attack on the Christian religion. In each of the above instances, modernity appears to promote a narrative in competition with the Christian story, be it the story of cosmic process, human origins and destiny, or the story of Israel and the life of Jesus. Lonergan, however, refuses a defensive, condemnatory stance. In his reading, the situation calls for a discerning appreciation of what is valid in the development of modernity and an understanding of how that validity is achieved. That discernment requires coming to understand the operations that constitute the practice of modern scientists and modern historians and the immanent norms that govern that practice. Eddington’s tables, composed mostly of empty space, clash with the common sense experience of the solidity of those objects. In that clash, Lonergan perceived the emergence of a critical and methodic exigence, a need to reflectively grasp the pattern of operations that comprises human knowing in all its instances, be they common sense or theoretic. Thus, he pursues the three questions that form the agenda of *Insight*: what am I doing when I am knowing, why is that knowing, and, finally, what do I know when I do it?

For the traditional self-understanding of Christian faith, the seemingly competitive narratives produced by modern empirical science and the discipline of critical history function like Eddington’s tables. Modern culture presents Christian faith with a critical and methodic exigence that requires a new mediation of the meaning of that faith beyond common sense and theory. To meet that exigence, Lonergan carries the turn to the subject initiated, but in various ways, foreshortened by modern philosophers to its full term. With modern

philosophy, he turns to the world of interiority, of human subjectivity, and in fostering a discovery of the response to the three questions of *Insight*, he invites one to appropriate the immanent norms for meaningful discourse, the norms operative in the practice of both empirical science and critical history and in a theology that would mediate between the Christian religion and the present cultural matrix. The upshot is an account of transcendental or generalized empirical method of which each discipline, science, history, and theology, comprises a distinct specification.

Modernity presents the challenge of a critical and methodic exigence, and that exigence finds fulfillment in the differentiation of interiority as a realm of meaning beyond common sense and theory. The shift to interiority proved operative in the procedure by which Lonergan derived his theological analysis of history. The general categories with which he articulates the elements of interiority in his account of transcendental method provided a base for projecting the ideal lines of historical progress in achieving the human good. Those same general categories functioned to provide a context for securing the meaning of the special theological category, sin, by relating it to the process by which bias impedes and distorts development, both individual and social. They likewise came into play in erecting the heuristic of redemption that flowed from the analysis of sin. Redemption would have to overcome the downward, contracting spiral of dehumanization that draws its dynamism from human sinfulness. Redemption would have to engage and transform human subjectivity in its individual-psychological and collective-social dimensions.

Finally, the shift to the third stage of meaning, interiority, determines the full meaning of the Law of the Cross that Lonergan articulates in his third soteriological thesis. In that thesis, he is proposing to formulate the intrinsic intelligibility of redemption as affirmed by diverse scriptural statements and by the derived doctrine of satisfaction. Scholastic theology, with its traditional question about the *convenientia* of the economy of salvation, of the incarnation, passion, death, and resurrection of Christ, provides the context for

Lonergan's thesis. Within that context, he turns back to scripture, and finds there, the three-step pattern of the Law of the Cross—death as the consequence of sin, the transformation of death by love, the ensuing blessing of new life—manifest in the various ways in which scripture affirms Christ's redemptive significance. This three-step pattern Lonergan proposes as the "essence" of redemption.

Lonergan draws the categories of the formula—sin, death, life—from Scripture, and there, they share the symbolic, imaginative character proper to the New Testament as common sense religious expression. Death, for example, connotes more than simply the cessation of biological activity, and Lonergan's analysis of sin offers a means of specifying the content of the connotative dimension of the image. Death connotes the effects of the biases, of humankind's failure, even refusal, to heed the imperatives of religious, moral, and intellectual development, the dynamic processes of dehumanization that engulf our humanity on the individual and social levels.

The second step of the Law of the Cross highlights the transformative power of the acceptance of death out of love. Such acceptance does not betoken the limp passivity so scorned by Nietzsche. Empowered by love—of God, of neighbor, of one's true self—one actively refuses the false practicality of general bias and accepts the sanctions imposed by a society and culture in which the ideological self-justifications of individual and group bias enjoy the plausibility of the self-evident. Beyond acceptance of the costs incurred from without, such active refusal also requires a more interior entry into dying. The roots of bias lie within us all, and they provide the nexus whereby we are socialized into the dehumanizing dynamics of society and culture. Hence, the notion of self-transcendence that defines Lonergan's anthropology implies a deeper entry into death, the death involved in negating what is undeveloped, biased, and distorted in the self to be transcended.

Through love, then, death is transformed. From an expression of the dehumanizing dynamics unleashed by the biases, dying becomes an affirmation of the unconditional value of refusing those dynamics as

they find concrete form in society and culture, cost what it may, and in oneself. Dying, if accepted out of love, is transformed. The third step of the Law of the Cross quickly follows. Fidelity to the exigencies of self-transcendence, empowered by the gift of love, opens onto new life, the fullness of authentic human existence.

With his third thesis, Lonergan moves soteriology beyond common sense and theory into the realm of interiority, the third stage of meaning. The Law of the Cross articulates the *convenientia* of redemption through the incarnation, life, death, and resurrection of Christ, the meaning of the Christian mystery. That mystery mediates the gift of God's love in Christ, and thus, introduces into history a community whose mission is to spread the good news of that love, to denounce and resist all that opposes it, to transform society and culture in consonance with it, and thus, to release human creativity for joyous progress in the human good. That mission, however, demands a price. In a history constituted in part by Lonergan's second vector, by the dynamics of sin, the gift of God's love is cruciform. Christian religious conversion unfolds through the Law of the Cross.

Lonergan's transposition of the soteriological tradition into the realm of interiority yields a clear vision of the redemptive role of the Christian community in history. By that same transposition, his soteriology also achieves a certain universality. Besides expressing the *convenientia* of the Christian mystery, the Law of the Cross also captures the dynamics of self-transcendence in a world infected with sin. Authentic human existence does not follow simply from a progressive realization of human potential. The path to authenticity lies through death, death to the results of bias and the hold they obtain over one, and what empowers that acceptance of death is the gift of love, a gift ultimately grounded in the Spirit of God. Thus, we may take Lonergan to suggest, redemption is occurring wherever women and men live lives of self-sacrificing love, and religions are redemptive to the extent that they promote such love.¹³⁵

135. Lonergan, *Method in Theology*, 55.